

# WGE:MAG

THE MAGAZINE FOR THE WORLD'S GAMING ELITE

WGE - ISSUE 4



## SWEET TALKING

The Man Behind The Twisted Mouth



**DEUS EX**  
WELCOME  
TO THE  
REVOLUTION

04



**A+E  
NETWORKS**  
TV'S A SOCIAL  
GAME

36



**MAJESCO**  
ZUMBA'S THE  
RIGHT STEP

48

ALSO INSIDE: CHILD'S PLAY » XENONAUTS » MMO LIFE



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# > HELLO

## Welcome to World Gaming Executives

John Armstrong  
WGE Director



**H**ere we are in our 4th Edition of  
WGE:MAG. Thanks to everyone for  
your feedback and appreciation.

Please keep downloading and if you do enjoy reading the magazine, please tell all your friends, colleagues and associates.

And for my friends who pointed out that I look 'grumpy' in the previous profile photo, I've updated it.

An additional aspect of WGE, that a number of our readers may not yet be aware of, is WGE Gamevoices Network.

The Gamevoices network hosts a wide range of acting talent featuring some of the biggest names in the industry including Charles Martinet (Super Mario), Adam Howden (Anders in Dragon Age and also Tintin in the video game), Zach Hanks (Captain Macmillan - Call of Duty), David Sobolov (Halo Wars - Arbiter) and many more stars you'll easily recognise.

Though the network is not all about big name voice actors; Gamevoices includes and actively encourages voice actors looking to break into the video games industry.

The days of paying massive fees to Hollywood celebrity actors for cameos in new games are dwindling. For most indie studios they never existed.

Gamevoices network allows access to thousands of actors, with whom developers can discuss acting in games and offer employment.

Showreel audio and video are available on site.

There is no charge for either party to join the site. Take a look at [www.gamevoices.co.uk](http://www.gamevoices.co.uk)

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# > CONTENTS

04

Dues Ex  
**Talk about  
a revolution**



08

Twisted Metal  
**Not all sugar  
is sweet**



14

Brasil  
Game Show  
**Games go big  
in Brasil**



16

Child's Play  
**How to make  
games for children**



18

Back To  
The Future  
**Gaming spec  
gone large**



23

Maria Ho  
**Breaking down  
the barriers**



25

Xenonauts  
**Alien invaders  
in the sky!**



29

Star Arcade  
**Gaming goes  
social**



32

Nuclei 3D  
**An unreal  
experience**



36

AE Networks  
**Pawn Stars make  
the grade**





# Deus Ex!

## Talk about a revolution

**D**eus Ex: Human Revolution proved to be one of the biggest hits of the past year. The critically acclaimed RPG has won a new army of fans following its release in August 2011, a legion of admirers to add to the huge following the game had collected from its first incarnation in 2000.

► Developed by Canadian studio, Eidos Montreal and published by Square Enix, the game is a prequel of the original Deus Ex title but the 11 year gap between release has took none of the shine off of the series.

WGE:MAG sent resident reporter Antonio Ribeiro, director of LightDesk Productions and producer of AnimaSerra Festival to speak with Deus Ex's Game Director, Jean-Francois Dugas.

**Antonio Ribeiro:** Since the first Deus Ex game in 2000 how has the gaming industry changed and how has that affected the development of Deus Ex: Human Revolution?

**Jean-Francois Dugas:** I think we have more and more people playing games, there is more variety in terms of game genres. In the last few years, we saw increasing production values in games too. So, in a sense, we're in a crowded market like never before and production values help games to stand out. Deus Ex was developed in a time when these factors weren't as prevalent, so we knew that we had to take that kind of stuff into account in order to make Deus Ex: Human Revolution unique.

**"We wanted a fresh start on the franchise and make it unique and standalone. Therefore, you do not need to be an old Deus Ex fan to appreciate the game..."**

**AR:** Deus Ex: Human Revolution's storyline is actually a prequel to the original. Is this because you felt the need to give the game a better basis and understanding?

**JFD:** It's a prequel for several reasons. First, we wanted a fresh start on the franchise and make it unique and standalone. Therefore, you do not need to be an old Deus Ex fan to appreciate the game – we have a new main character and supporting characters that you'll encounter during the journey.



Second, in the original timeline of Deus Ex, there was an era where mechanically-augmented people started to burgeon in society before the event of nano-augmented people. The distinction lied in the fact that nano-augmentations were invisible and the mechanical augmentations were not. We thought it would be an interesting theme to explore from both a gameplay and an ethical/moral perspective (the benefits and dangers of such a world where some can afford to get augmented while others can't).

**AR:** What were the most difficult challenges to make this game?

**JFD:** Building the studio and the team while reviving the Deus Ex franchise.

We also had to convince the team that building content that might not be seen by all players was necessary. It seems obvious but in a competitive industry where every dollar counts, it can be tough to justify that kind of vision.

**AR:** A game like Deus Ex HR requires a team of writers to create all the text and the numerous variations in the story because of the player's decision made at every step. Did you find this influenced much of the game art, doing scenarios and environments that would only be accessed in the event of a specific response?



**JFD:** Yes and no. We have an organic, yet structured process in which art, story and gameplay are kind of built together. This allows departments to influence each other and, as we move forward, it gives us the flexibility to adapt to new ideas that might arise on the way.

**AR:** How long did it take from the initial conception of the game until the finished product?

**JFD:** While I can't specify, what I can say is that Eidos-Montreal was founded in 2007 and this is the studio's first game.

**AR:** How many people worked on Deus Ex Human Revolution? Was it a global effort? Any developers from my homeland Brazil?

**JFD:** We had quite a few foreigners on the team from countries such as the U.S., France, Canada, Netherlands, China, Morocco.

And yes, we have one mofo crazy Brazilian programmer. He's passionate and very professional. He's also a big metal fan, like me – we have a lot of fun together! He's actually at the origin of one of our easter eggs in the game in which we pay homage to Charlotte the Harlot, a character featured in several Iron Maiden songs.

**AR:** What do you know about the Brazilian game market?

**JFD:** I know that Brazil is very passionate about their video games, and is the biggest market for Deus Ex: Human Revolution on PC in South America! And, of course, I'm a big fan of Sepultura from their beginnings to Roots.

**AR:** We know that Montreal is a major base of games development today. How is the gaming market in Canada and the participation of Montréal in the world of game development today?

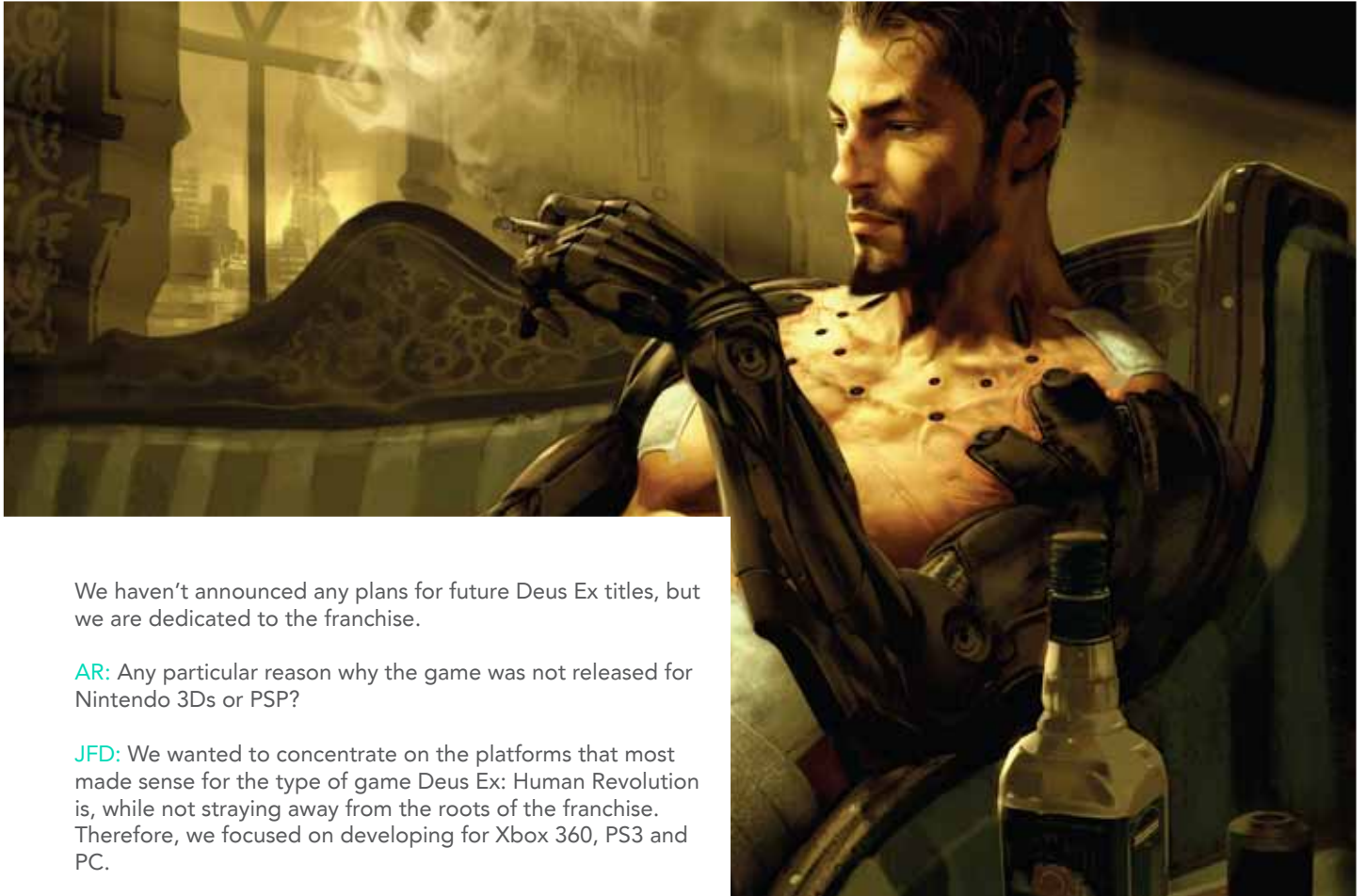
**JFD:** I think that the Montreal game industry is quite vibrant with a lot of talented developers and I'm happy to be part of it; we can be proud of our contribution to the market landscape.

**AR:** The game has received fantastic acclaim for its artwork. What were the processes which went into the artistic direction?

**JFD:** The hardest part was nailing the art direction and the design of the main character, Adam. We spent about two years on the iteration of him. It was hard because we didn't have much reference for what we were trying to achieve (e.g. cyber-renaissance), so, we were constantly experimenting - going too far sometimes, not enough at other times. Basically, finding the right balance, the perfect recipe, was tremendously hard.

**AR:** What has been the reaction of the gaming public to Deus Ex: Human Revolution? Are there plans for another game in the near future?

**JFD:** The reception from gamers has been amazing and a little overwhelming. We obviously wanted to create a great game that lived up to the Deus Ex name, but Deus Ex: Human Revolution has exceeded our initial expectations. To read all of the e-mails and forum posts by fans telling us about their appreciation for the game is pretty awesome.



We haven't announced any plans for future Deus Ex titles, but we are dedicated to the franchise.

**AR:** Any particular reason why the game was not released for Nintendo 3Ds or PSP?

**JFD:** We wanted to concentrate on the platforms that most made sense for the type of game Deus Ex: Human Revolution is, while not straying away from the roots of the franchise. Therefore, we focused on developing for Xbox 360, PS3 and PC.

**AR:** It's possible to progress through the game with a variety of different scenarios and this gives the game an extended shelf-life. Do you think this was a nice gimmick or is it just a representation of history itself?

**JFD:** Providing gamers with the freedom of choice creates a customized experience for each person. One of the coolest things that I witnessed was seeing and hearing players compare their experiences with the game and how each person had a completely different playthrough. If someone wants to play more aggressively, they can. If they want to play more stealthily, that's OK too. If they're into exploration, there's a ton to do. We didn't want players to feel restricted in how they played the game. In turn this also allows for gamers to play again and have a totally new experience.

**AR:** What would you expect from someone who wishes to enter the gaming industry? What skills and experience do they need to have?

**JFD:** Talent is number one, but that's not all. You need to really want to work hard and to build great games. So, dedication, patience, structure, analytical and communication skills is essential.

You also need creativity, but I'm not only referring to the "Hey! I got a good idea" concept. I'm referring to the ability to be creative in problem solving. I'd say that this is the most important part of creativity as having a 'good idea' is a skill shared by most human beings. It's what you're able to do with the creativity to deal with certain constraints that makes you stand out.

**AR:** Eidos has previously created classic games such as Tomb Raider, Legacy of Kain, Hitman, amongst others. Of those listed, two have become movies. Do you think Deus Ex has the potential to become a film or even a television series?

**"I personally think Deus Ex: Human Revolution could make for a cool movie because of Adam's distinct personality, the rich story and the visuals of the world, but don't know of any actual plans for a movie. "**

**JFD:** I personally think Deus Ex: Human Revolution could make for a cool movie because of Adam's distinct personality, the rich story and the visuals of the world, but don't know of any actual plans for a movie.

**AR:** Have you sought the experience and expertise of any outside agencies? Do your programmers and developers work closely with weapons experts, psychologists and engineers?

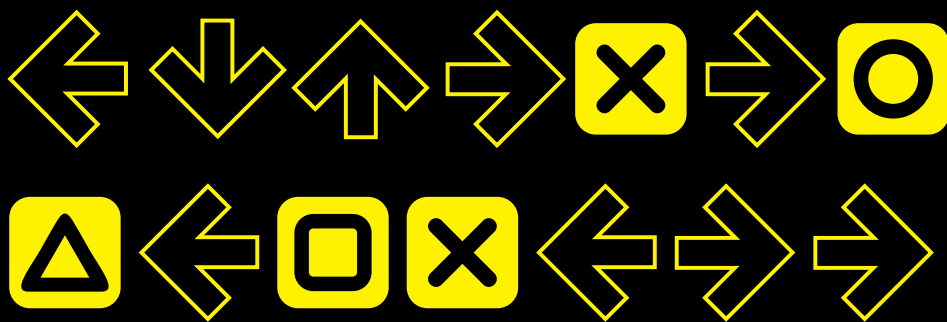
**JFD:** We always made sure that we put our people in contact with the right external experts. For example, animators, sound engineers and designers went on a shooting range to fire weapons in order to accurately portray weapons in the game.

**AR:** Have Eidos considered a multi-player option for Deus Ex: Human Revolution?

**JFD:** We did not include multiplayer because we wanted to focus on delivering the best solo Deus Ex experience possible, which is at the heart of the franchise.

**AR:** Finally what are Eidos' plans for the near future?

**JFD:** You'll have to stay tuned!



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# Your next move should be easy.

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# Sweet Tooth is Not Voice-over Candy

**S**ome say J.S. Gilbert is a hybrid Advertising- Marketing- Production guy... maybe the product of old school meets new school with a little attention deficit thrown in. He is definitely a storyteller, writer, voice-over actor, producer, director and more.

► Rebecca of LoveThatRebecca.com, fellow voice actor and host of "Love That Voiceover", had a nice long interview with J.S. Gilbert about his creative career, including developing the character SWEET TOOTH from Twisted Metal-Play Station 3, experiencing the birth of video games in Silicon Valley / San Francisco California in the 80's and 90's, smattered with pearls of wisdom. The complete podcast interview with J.S. Gilbert is available at [blogtalkradio.com/LoveThatRebecca](http://blogtalkradio.com/LoveThatRebecca).

**Rebecca:** Let's follow along your video gaming career. You have a very fascinating experience - probably different than some of the many people who are in the small group of really heavily working video gaming voice over talent.

**JS:** The start was very organic. I was a gamer, an early gamer. I played Atari Console games, the Commodore 64 and I belonged to SIG's (Special Interest Groups) where we would meet once a month, sometimes twice a month. The different manufacturers that were making software and products would come and talk about things.

We would discuss all aspects of the gaming machines. I wrote a program in early basic to help me keep track of my database and another one called 'Smart Typewriter'. So I was really kind of into that world. I got to meet people who worked at both Atari and Commodore, then later on at SEGA.

"...after I did the character I started getting fan mail and that was twelve years ago. I doubt a month goes by that I don't get e-mail from somebody where they say, "Are you the J.S. Gilbert that did the voice of Sweet Tooth? He's my favorite..."

**Rebecca:** But you were helping them develop part of the games, so how did it bridge into voice-over?

**JS:** Right. In the games it started actually with me going down there and beta testing software or they would have various products that they were coming out with like Pen Plotters and things like that.





**Rebecca:** As a gamer you were testing things?

**JS:** Yeah, I was working with all those products and then they kind of discovered that I did all of these funny voices and could act.

**Rebecca:** As you were playing the game and just joking around, hanging out, entertaining them in your own way, making voices.

**JS:** Yeah! As they started looking at how they were introducing audio into the games. It started out like simple sounds – “plinkah, plinkah plinkah...” and it moved into ‘how are we going to get voice in here’? They were working on developing what are called Kodecs [to make space for the audio] - to squish down the voice and put it on disk and introduce it into the games. So as they were developing these things, they would have me read and do different voices [to test the technology]. I was sort of a voice ‘guinea pig’ for some of that early stuff and got to know the developers. Then as that moved into actual game work, they would ask me to come in and voice the games.



**Rebecca:** This was fun for you I assume? You were a gamer so this was like living and breathing what you love when you were helping these companies.

**JS:** Yeah! The early stuff, when they would bring me in and ask me to do some voice work or whatever, they were paying me off with products! They would give me new software or a new printer or whatever. At one point I had everything you could own for the Atari 2600 Game console! I had every single thing like early wireless stuff or a Pen Plotter and three or four different kinds of printers! I had everything that you could imagine because that’s how they were paying me. Oh, it was great!

**Rebecca:** So the gaming industry develops audio, then besides effects some voice gets involved. Then it becomes dialogue. Then it becomes more, and more and more. You did voice-over in Battle Tashinden, Pitkin, Panzer General, Thunderscape, NHL Hockey, NFL Football, Dark Wizards, Star Ocean Sites... you have a large list of credits.

**JS:** Most of the work that I’ve done isn’t even credited!

**Rebecca:** Right. You said that it’s there in a whole bunch of internal libraries.

**JS:** At that point voice-over was getting to be a little bit more of my world. I’m actually contacting companies and getting to do some different things. At this point I’d done some work on a couple of documentaries, commercial work, corporate work, some narration, a couple of books on tape. So all of these things have been done basically just marketing myself. I still had not obtained an agent at this point. In fact, I don’t even think at this point I really even had a demo, quite frankly.”

**Rebecca:** Interesting. You really fell into it organically as you said.

**JS:** This was a time when if you were auditioning you generally went to either the ad agency or the client - you went somewhere and they would hook up a tape recorder and you would just read into it! I knew the questions to ask



of the person who was there with me running the tape recorder. I would find out if they were the writer or the producer, or how they saw me or the voice talent relating to the work. I was very lucky at that point. Again, the competition wasn't something that we had worldwide or even statewide. Most of the people that I would be competing against were in my neck of the woods.

At the same time the advertising industry in San Francisco became very, very strong... boutiquey and everybody, all of the clients wanted to come here and make their ads then go to wine country for the weekend, stay at a bed & breakfast! So we became the place to go and a lot of the (ad agency) emphasis had shifted away from Los Angeles, Chicago and New York. San Francisco was now getting real big for it's britches. I think like right now we really have maybe about ten professional recording studios in San Francisco that focus on Voice Over or dialogue recording heavily. I would say, back then, there might have been a hundred.

**Rebecca:** Wow. Are we talking mid-nineties or somewhere in the nineties?

**JS:** Yeah, we're talkin' the 90s. So I had this going for me. Then we had the gaming world kind of coming up and

all of a sudden a publication comes out called The Bay Area Guide to Interactive, something or other, I can't remember what it was. I picked this thing up and would just call people out of it and say, "Hey, are you interested in somebody who understands interactive audio for video games and things like that?" And literally people would say, "When can you get here?"

**"I don't know if you know who I am, but I was the voice of Sweet Tooth. I also was Axel and No Face. I did like four or five characters in that game." I said, "It sure would be nice to be able to read for 'God of War' or something like that."**

Every single kitchen table in the Bay Area it seems had a few people working on some sort of interactive project. That's what they were called back then: Interactive Projects.

**Rebecca:** Now it seems like the status quo. Then it was really new.

**JS:** Yeah. So people didn't understand how to write for these things because what the player might do would cause

something new to happen but you had to have continuity. The other thing that was happening at the time was that the audio being recorded had to be concatenated.

**Rebecca:** I saw that term and I don't know what the heck that means. Do you want to tell us all?

**JS:** When you call up the operator and they say, "The number you have reached, 6 8 5 4 7 8 5" so it just means that you can put these words together. In Dark Wizard for example, it was, "Wizard"... "pick up the"... "book". Then they could use the first part and the end part and the middle part separately. So instead it could be, "Wizard.. pick up the.. scepter" or "Demon.. pick up the.. book."

You had to say it so that it would make sense when they concatenated it, when they put the words together. In one of the early football games we had to do that. You had to say the players names so that they would sound OK at the beginning, middle or end of a sentence.

It's not done much anymore. It's done a little bit still in Interactive Voice Response for voice mail systems. You call a bank and they are giving you your balance. "You currently have Three.. Thousand.. Six.. Hundred.."

**" Because evil characters never think they are evil. They think that they are completely and 100% in the right. They are saving the world. Everything they do makes sense and that's their rational."**

**Rebecca:** (Laughing) Do you do that still, your voice sounds awfully familiar?

**JS:** Yeah, I do some of that. I do some voice mail. Some IVR...

**Rebecca:** Now I want to talk to you about video game voice over work that you are doing more recently... there is a character that is kind of scary. His name is Marcus Caine but everybody refers to him as Sweet Tooth.

**JS:** Some call him Needles Caine, too.

**Rebecca:** I've seen both, OK! That's for Play Station 3, Twisted Metal Series of Car Combat Games. It's a fascinating game and you called it your "Crown Jewel". Why?

**JS:** Yeah, the funny thing about it was, after I did the character I started getting fan mail and that was twelve years ago. I doubt a month goes by that I don't get e-mail from somebody where they say, "Are you the J.S. Gilbert that did the voice of Sweet Tooth? He's my favorite and..."

Now, when I talk to people and they ask, "What games were you in?" and I answer "Well I was both the bad guy and the good guy in the original Toshinden and Tekken..." and their initial reaction is "oh, oh, ok." Then continuing I say, "I was also... Do you know Twisted Metal Black? I was Sweet Tooth in there." and they go, "SWEET TOOTH!?"

So, it's just seems to be my defining role! It's really funny because David Jaffe - I kind of re-united with him a few years ago online on Facebook.

**Rebecca:** For those of you who don't know, David Jaffe is the game designer and he also directs the talent.

**JS:** Yeah, and Keith Farley was also a director on it too.

**Rebecca:** You re-connected with David Jaffe on Facebook of all places?

**JS:** I just sent a message to him on Facebook and I said something along the lines to him like "I don't know if you know who I am, but I was the voice of Sweet Tooth. I also was Axel and No Face. I did like four or five characters in that game." I said, "It sure would be nice to be able to read for 'God of War' or something like that."

Then he sent me an e-mail back and said, 'Well, I'm so glad that you got in touch with me. We are actually working on doing a new Twisted Metal and how would you like to be Sweet Tooth again? I'm like, "Sure!"

**Rebecca:** You've really just done this new reprisal but you really can't talk about it, is that right?

**JS:** To a certain extent I can talk a little bit about it. I mean I can talk a little bit about the process and so forth. There's a lot of video about it online. David lets out stuff all of the time. The game should be out pretty soon. I have to be just be a little careful and a little guarded about what I say.

**Rebecca:** Let's talk about character development. I would like to know how you or he or how you both defined Sweet Tooth. You said "in the reprise of Sweet Tooth" and then "there was also the origination of Sweet Tooth". You said Sweet Tooth had a quiet way of being menacing and that, to you, he was more of a tortured artist than anything else.

**JS:** Yeah. When I originally went in to do the Sweet Tooth voice, this was a franchise that was doing well. But I would say that the level of direction that I got was more reliant upon me as the actor doing an interpretation. Maybe there was less at stake, you know? Those were simpler times and games cost less to produce...

So my kind of interpretation of getting all of this backstory on him was the same as when you go about doing an "evil" character. The worst thing that you can do is say to yourself, 'Oh, I'm evil.' Because evil characters never think they are evil. They think that they are completely and 100% in the right. They are saving the world. Everything they do makes sense and that's their rational.

**Rebecca:** Right. They are justified in their behavior.

**JS:** Totally justified. So he was justified - but he was insane. So I played the character in a way I felt was rather multi-dimensionally. His voice had a lot of fluctuation and it went in a lot of different directions. There were at times playfulness and so on.

**"The games can get really complex and the PS3 is an incredible gaming system to develop on because you can use the underlying instruction set that's built into the PS3 to create all kinds of incredible effects and give your sound realism."**





We started work on the project almost a couple of years ago doing some preliminary stuff, just teasers and things like that. What became clear was that the new game, the new direction that they wanted him to go in was that he was, however many years later, extremely dark right now. I would say where he is at right now is super, unbelievably scary.

**Rebecca:** OH I have seen in the trailer that's out right now. Really scary! Now I haven't played this game before but I watched some video of how the game is played - some footage of a gamer so you see what the gamer did and how that game goes. This is basically a vehicle driven by this character but the vehicle has a head on it and the whole style is this clown with a flaming head. A dark, dark, dark scary clown. The worst nightmare scary clown with flaming head to boot.

**JS:** Clown's are scary enough without flaming heads.

**Rebecca:** Exactly!

**JS:** But this guy even more so.

**Rebecca:** I've also seen some live action elements put together of this guy. I'm just curious how did you voice him? Were there dialogue lines? Were there action moments? I know that they have certain scenes that get developed for games. Can you elaborate a little bit on it?

**JS:** Yeah, there are a bunch of scenes that are the videos where the story moves along in kind of a linear sense. [It explains] what is going to happen and it doesn't relate a whole lot necessarily to what the gamer is doing. Those videos were fairly fleshed out before I went in to do my VO. It partially had a sense of meeting a time constraint, because this video is going to be on the screen for thirty seconds and I need to say something that falls into a certain part

within the time frame, or whatever. But other than that it was reacting to what the character in the video was doing and being appropriate to that moment, really being in that moment.

Then there's also the end game audio. As the gamer is doing things, that's going to determine what my character says, does or both. That has a lot more to do with the real specifics of the moment. It might be where the character is saying something loud because there could be percussive bombs going off or things of that nature. There're a lot of things that into the creation of this rather than just saying stuff. You have to think of what kind of music will be playing along with it. What the sound effects are, etc.

**"What's cool about online games, though, you get to do things that are like taunts, which aren't in a lot of games."**

There are some games that I've done in the past where it can get super layered. You can have as many as 180 different sounds being triggered at once. The games can get really complex and the PS3 is an incredible gaming system to develop on because you can use the underlying instruction set that's built into the PS3 to create all kinds of incredible effects and give your sound realism. There's built in surround sound development. It's just really incredible for anybody who is an audio designer.

**Rebecca:** How crazy does this make you when you are behind the mic and are trying to do these lines? Do they tell you what is exactly happening so you match your response to that line?

**JS:** I'll ask, sometimes I'll guess. Sometimes they will tell me specifically, oh, yeah this is where blah, blah, blah happens.

Yesterday I went in and recorded a game for seven or eight characters for a new Zynga game. I just had lines. A lot of times on the script they will give you lines and tell you what your intonation is: Respectfully, fearfully, saying this to his arch enemy. Yesterday they didn't have any interpretations. It was OK because I had a director standing right there. No big deal. But it was interesting to see how I might say a line and then he [the director] would say, oh no, such and such is happening. Then I would go, "Aahh, OK."

**Rebecca:** (laughing) Right.

**JS:** For example when we would do these early games, you might have a line - say there is a rug merchant and the rug merchant says, "You need to go to the big palace and see Habeeb before you can come and get a rug." Then you are tasked to do that. (There was some simple stuff back then) Then you would have screens where you say, "What are you doing back here?"

But [as a VO actor] if you didn't understand the context of, "What are you doing back here?" and that line might be delivered to six different characters... I might be saying that to a guy I hate, an enemy or to a beautiful woman or so on and so forth. So you had to understand the context of the game in which that line might come up.

**Rebecca:** But sometimes it's written and sometimes it's through the director's direction?

**JS:** Exactly. Or it can be both.

**Rebecca:** Is there any difference that you can describe between doing a PlayStation style game voice-over work and an online game voice-over work, or is it all pretty much the same?

**JS:** Well, there're a lot of different genres & casual games. I've done Sam and Max or The Bone, some of the Zynga games, iPhone games. They're called casual games because they don't necessarily get hardcore gamers. A lot of these games are meant to be played in just a few hours. They are looking for a different sort of demographic in terms of the game player. Then there are puzzle games. Then there are games designed for kids.

**Rebecca:** So it's really based on the genre more so than whether it is online or not?

**JS:** Yeah. What's cool about online games, though, you get to do things that are like taunts, which aren't in a lot of games. You are playing against other players so your character gets to say nasty things to them and they can say nasty things back.

But also, the online games continue to develop other levels. For example, L.O.T.R.O. (Lord of the Rings online) brings me in every couple of months or so to do different character voices. I get to be this really cool dragon, elves, dwarfs and all kinds of things. Probably ninety percent of the people that are playing L.O.T.R.O. that will probably never hear me. These levels are for hard core gamers that have gotten to the high, high levels! L.O.T.R.O. continues to churn out new challenges for them on a regular basis so these people can still play the game.



**Rebecca:** That is cool. But for you as a voice actor - the voice work itself doesn't really change between games online or games in a PlayStation machine?

**JS:** No. They fall into different categories. How realistic do you want these characters to sound? Do you want them to sound like guys in a movie? Do you want them to sound cartoony? And again, that has a lot to do with the genre of the game, the type of game and so forth; Zynga games, casual games, those types tend to use less audio, tend to be a little less complicated. Some of the really complex games that are out there are designed to play on very, very heavy duty computer systems. So there are probably people who are out there playing casual games and Zynga games and they couldn't even play some of the newer games that are coming out because of the demands. You have to have a certain graphics card. You have to have a huge amount of memory in order to play them properly.

**Rebecca:** Wow!

**JS:** In fact gaming has probably had more to do with driving the developments and technology in terms of audio and video in the computer world more than just about any other application.

**Rebecca:** True! In staying up with tech trends I hear a lot about that! Well thank you so much for joining me It's been a pleasure getting to know you today.

**JS:** Thank you, same here!

Find out more and get the full interview at [www.blogtalkradio.com/LoveThatRebecca](http://www.blogtalkradio.com/LoveThatRebecca)

XBOX 360.

XBOX 360

## The Boys From Brasil

**W**idely regarded as the biggest gaming conference in Latin America, the Brasil Game Show has gone from strength-to-strength since its inaugural event in 2009. Whilst basking in the glory of a hugely successful 2011 conference, the BGS is now preparing for an even better 2012 event, expanding its operation over the country's biggest two cities – Sao Paulo and Rio de Janeiro.

WGE:MAG interrupted those hectic preparations to grab a quick chat with Brasil Game Show's director, Marcelo Tavares.

► "Since 2009, BGS has grown and established itself as the largest games fair in Latin America," Tavares boasted as he looked back on several years of success.

"On June 21, 2009, the first edition of the show was held after three years without any games industry event in Brazil. As a businessman and a collector of video games, with the biggest collection in the country, I decided to bet on the challenge of creating the first Rio Game Show that had 4,000 attendees.

"On November 28th and 29th, 2009, we completely revamped and expanded to a National Show, more than 8,000 people attended the second edition of the event held for the first time in a modern convention center where it was three times the size of the first edition.

"In 2010 the event had not stopped growing. The show space tripled and once again the number of exhibitors doubled. Visitors to the show reached the milestone of 30,000 people.

"Last year the event became the Brasil Game Show and in the process became the largest game show in South America. Ninety exhibitors were present and more than 60,000 people attended the event and experienced access to breaking news in the gaming industry."

"Last year we exceeded expectations and reaffirmed our title as the largest game show in Latin America, tapping into the public desire and reaching the maximum capacity of SulAmérica Convention Center with more than 60,000 people..."

Whilst Brazil is often overlooked by the key influencers in the global gaming industry, Tavares believes that it is only a matter of time before people sit up and notice the gaming scene in South America, pointing to some impressive statistics as supporting evidence.





He says: "Economically stable and with a large, young population, Brazil has been growing in the gaming market. According to estimates, the country has about 45 million players. These users play on consoles, portable, computers, cellphones, tablets or even on social networks like Facebook, Orkut and Google +. According to Nielsen, the country has 78 million internet users. Brazil has the largest base of mobile phones in the world with more than 200 million devices. Recently, the country took third place in worldwide computer sales."

If last year's BGS is a barometer of success then this year's prospective attendees have plenty to look forward to. Not only did BGS 2011 break all previous records, its partnership with Ronald McDonald House helped provide over 10 tonnes of food for the families of children with cancer.

"Last year we exceeded expectations and reaffirmed our title as the largest game show in Latin America, tapping into the public desire and reaching the maximum capacity of SulAmérica Convention Center with more than 60,000 people," Tavares explains.

"Visitors could play, first-hand, titles before release, and others which recently launched. About 90 companies participated in the fourth edition of the event, including Sony, NC Games, Seven, Microsoft, M-Coin, Vostu, Hazit Online Games, Level-Up!, Mentez, Warner, EA and Codemasters. Producers Yoshinori Ono and Zafer Coban attended, signing autographs and taking pictures with fans of the Street Fighter and Batman series."

With less than seven months before the 2012 BGS event, the wheels are already in motion for another top class conference. Tavares is excited at the plans for what is becoming one of the greatest gaming phenomenons in the southern hemisphere.

So what can we look forward to?

In 2012, seeking to expand its area of operation, the Brasil Game Show will become the premiere games fair in this country's two largest cities - Rio de Janeiro and São Paulo.

"Beginning with the next edition, the event will be biennial, alternating between the two cities. Between October 11th and 14th, 2012, São Paulo will host the largest gaming event in Latin America. We expect to see 80,000 visitors over the three days (Friday, Saturday and Sunday) plus an exclusive day for the press, professionals, officials and guests (Thursday). 180 booths will be bringing together the major gaming companies of the world."

The web site [www.brasilgameshow.com.br](http://www.brasilgameshow.com.br) provide all the information related to the event and contacts for those who wants to invest in Brazil.

**To view a video of last year's Brasil Games Show click here - [http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=3n5YdPr0f4&list=UUCroahB\\_nJSmvuU4lvfGa1A](http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=3n5YdPr0f4&list=UUCroahB_nJSmvuU4lvfGa1A)**





# A PIECE OF CAKE?

## Making educational games for children

**T**There are thousands of minigames for children in iOS, Android and in other platforms. Adding educational value to children's games brings a few new challenges on top of heavy competition. Children are extremely challenging audience for many reasons. Many of them can't read or have limited reading ability. They like repetition, great stories, full colors, nice animations and surprises. But they don't have as much patience as adults do. So they get bored very quickly.

► Someone said that when kids play they want to have fun, not learn. Luckily they appear not to be mutually exclusive, since children play millions of educational game sessions too.

A while ago kids' edugames were basically the same as simple 'work & task' books but with small animations and feedback. Then voice guidance, scoring systems and finally a real playing approach was added to edugames. Now the best educational games finally challenge some adults puzzle and even arcade games, whilst still combining educational value with great fun factor; this is by far the most challenging job when making edugames for children.

**"All in all I've found making games for children extremely good fun. Live user tests are the best part of it even if feedback is not always so great. Children really say what they feel."**

One interesting aspect related to the children's game genre is that our end customer and buyer are different persons. A typical mommy-kid dilemma, which creates many extra issues in game development. Children love coins, prizes, scores etc. But many parents feel that games, which have been created for younger children should not have scores and should not encourage competing with other children. The same problematic is seen in customer feedback. Written feedback is often given by player's Mom's and statistics for the playing session can give totally opposite messages. So it is pretty critical to really study feedback carefully before making changes in game design. And an ultimatum goal is naturally to keep both player & Mom happy.



Usability and game design are always challenging areas in children's games. It is pretty obvious that younger players, like 3-year-olds have totally different skills than oldest customers, 8-9-year-old children. One of our first games had three difficulty levels. So we tried many different ways, which would enable older children to skip the first easy levels but younger ones would not end up on too hard levels before knowing at least the basic game controls. Since most younger players are not able to read simple written difficulty levels (easy, medium etc.) are out of the question. So we tried small panda and big panda symbols.

Did it work? No. All the players wanted to be big pandas of course... So we noticed that this game design area needed some extra work. Today we might be half way there, but there is still plenty of room for improvement.

Moral and legislative considerations are also of key importance in children's games. The kids game industry has legal limitations from COPPA etc. Rules are getting stricter and it is clear that game developers can't follow individual users without their parents' permission. Developers can use summary data, averages and data, which is not related to specific users.

That makes follow-up and A/B testing a bit more challenging than for other game developers. Currently we know for example what is the average game session length for our games and how our games stand related to certain benchmarks. We can also follow in which game phase most children drop off and which part of the game they skip- if that is possible. But in most cases we don't know if a player who dropped was 4- or 8-year-old and if the player was a boy or a girl and so on. So we don't know exactly whether the game was too easy or too difficult for them or what, if anything, needs improvement.

Voice guidance also brings a specific kids game area problem. There is a need to update all the games constantly to keep them fresh and maintain momentum. In a typical arcade game it can mean one more field, new feature or characters etc. In children's games we also like to provide new content to keep the players happy. So for example our next game, Lola's Math Train has voice actors for 10 languages and some companies have even more language versions. If we have not planned updates in advance very carefully even a small change can become a big task. Sometimes naturally narrations can be avoided, but kids

just enjoy an exciting, interesting or calming spoken voice. And due to the educational nature of the games errors in localizations are just not acceptable.

All in all I've found making games for children extremely good fun. Live user tests are the best part of it even if feedback is not always so great. Children really say what they feel. We had a good example of that with our latest game project.

Before real user tests were supposed to start, I had a game test with my youngest daughter. I gave her a sneak peak and thought that now she's gonna be excited. But her feedback was a bit different and she just said "I don't want to play this game". We had failed in the most important thing; in combining the educational approach and fun factor. What can you do - it was pretty obvious we had a longer way to go before actual real user tests could begin.

I wanted to advertise our next game, Lola's Math Train here, but unfortunately the launch date has been postponed. The game has been returned to production until it satisfies my daughter and other beta testers.

Mika Heikinheimo CEO BEIZ



# BACK TO THE FUTURE

by Dwayne Mason

Quite some time ago - back when many of you reading this article today were still small children and others of you, like me, were just starting out with your careers in game development - many things in the game development industry were very different. Way back then (in the early 1990's) the industry was quite a different place than it is today. Games were much smaller, as were the teams that made them. The money involved was serious even then, but the amount of money allocated to complete game productions could seem almost 'quaint' by today's standards. Games were designed with game-play in mind first and everything else came second. Much of the 'magic' of the gaming experience was left to the imagination of the player, since the art displayed on screen was really still quite simple then.

Yet some key aspects of the industry remain much the same today as they were then. The scope and scale of game development projects have changed dramatically, it's true. And of course the dollar amounts commonly risked on - and earned by - single game titles today are exponentially higher than what they were then. Some of the tools and techniques that we wield in production today have evolved quite a bit too.

"Performance, memory and storage are not the limiting factors that they once were and because of this the art requirements for games developed for the current systems is at an all time high."

But as they say "Some things never change". Take the process of developing art for a game for example. Art development and art production today have many similarities to the way they were done back then. Game art is still first defined by the design of the project. The art still has to fit within the technical limitations of the game's specific technology, be those limits set by game engine performance or by overall platform specs. Game art still has to be produced on time and within pre-set budgetary parameters (at least in the vast majority of cases).

What has changed tremendously over the course of the last 18 to 20 years in game art development is the level of detail that is required for in-game art assets, and the sheer volume of art that is required by even an 'average' title these days. And these factors will only continue to increase as time goes by.





Consider this... Back in 1991 when I got my start as a professional working in game and CG animation - a valid form of art production I would argue - the top PC game of the day was Origin System's "Wing Commander - The 3D Space Combat Simulator". Wing Commander required a PC with a minimum 286 MHz CPU (with sound card, because anything beyond MIDI was still an optional upgrade in those days) and had a memory requirement of around 640k of RAM. Today a game like Infinity Blade can run on your handheld Smartphone and requires a speedy 600 MHz processor and 256 MB of RAM to throw it's (rather gorgeous) art around the screen with. Even without considering the vast differences in form factor, there is large evolutionary difference in the performance capabilities between an iPhone 3GS versus a 286 PC running Windows 3!

#### A quick (unofficial) comparison of specs:

##### Window 3.0 PC - 1990

- 16-bit CPU 286 MHz
- 640 K conventional memory
- Hercules, CGA, EGA, VGA Graphics Card

##### Playstation 2 (2000)

- 64-bit Emotion CPU @ 299 MHz
- 32 MB RDRAM
- 147.5 MHz Graphics Synthesizer w/4MB DRAM (can use system memory to process "offscreen" details), 16 pipelines, 48 GB/s bandwidth

##### Xbox

- 32-bit Coppermine-based 733 MHz Intel Pentium III derivative
- 64 MB SDRAM
- 233 MHz nVidia NV2A (uses system memory), 4 pipelines, 6.4 GB/s

##### iPhone 3GS

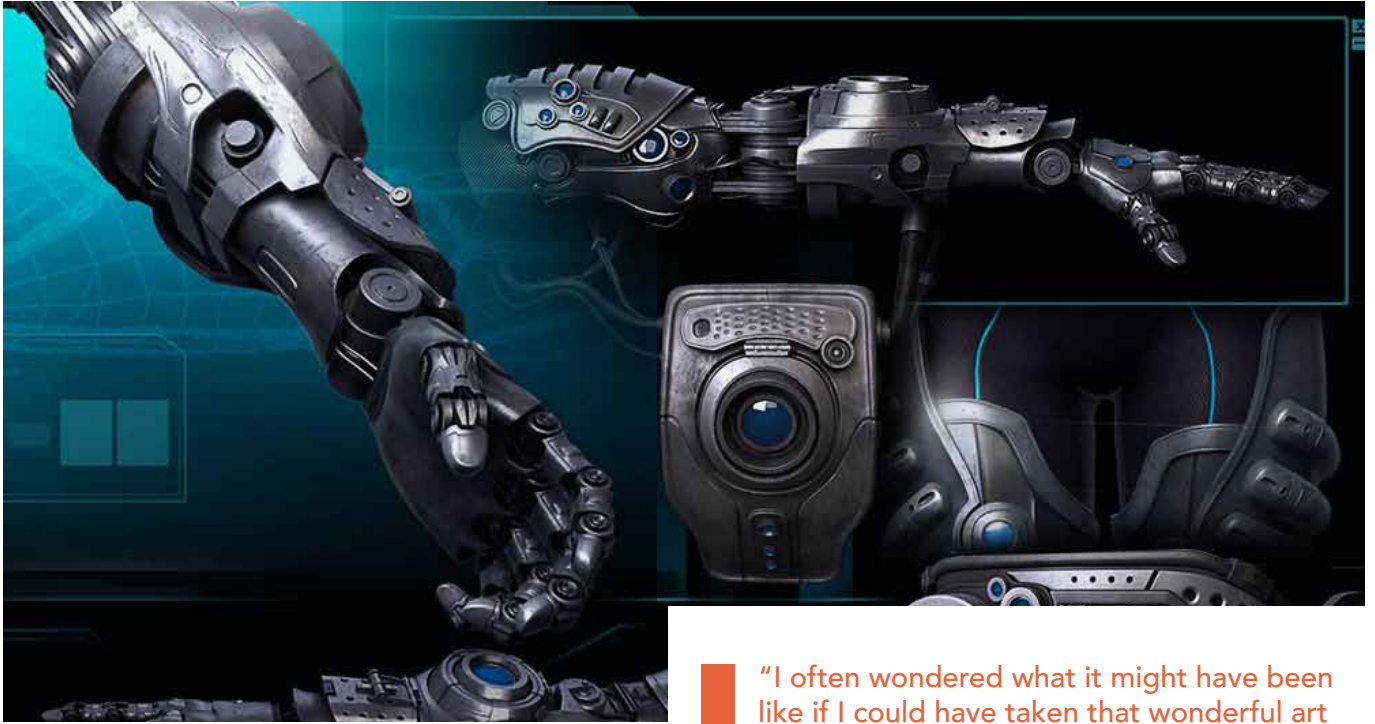
- Samsung S5PC100 ARM Cortex-A8 @ 600 MHz (not sure on 32/64-bit)
- 256 MB eDRAM
- 200 MHz PowerVR SGX535 GPU (uses system memory), 4 pipelines, 4.2 GB/s bandwidth

Performance, memory and storage are not the limiting factors that they once were and because of this the art requirements for games developed for the current systems is at an all time high.

The successors to PS3 and 360 will only increase the demand for more (and more detailed) art production. As platform games continue to evolve into more epic and 'film-like' experiences, so the art requirements for these titles will also continue to expand and grow. And of course the adoption rate of large format HD capable displays is at an all time high. In 2012 practically everyone has an HDTV. So today's games require much more art content than ever before, and of a much higher quality across the board. Nearly all of today's game art assets have to be able to hold up to close scrutiny when viewed by end users on large, very high-resolution HD displays.

Taken as a whole these factors present a relatively new challenge to development teams in the Interactive Entertainment Industry - How to create a LOT of art at a very high quality level, on time and within budget. The conventional approach would be to simply open up job requisitions and hire in the total number of artists required, who would then set about building all of the art for the game. Larger companies might sometimes move some of their artists from team to team based on current project needs, and smaller companies often have key artists actually owning a share of the game or of the project's royalties, or even part of the company itself. This helps when the artists have to work 80 hours a week for four months to ship a game...





The problem now, though, is the 'build all of the art' part of the equation. In many cases today to build all of the art for a project within the project's planned development cycle would mean hiring in and maintaining a team of 50 to 100+ full-time artists per project. Maybe even more for some of the larger projects. Good artists typically make good money, so it is not hard to see where this can create quite a dilemma. It is a dilemma that many teams face at companies both large and small.

Given today's art production requirements most teams can no longer justify the costs required to build and maintain an art team of a size that would be capable of producing the full amount of art required, at quality, for their entire game production. Today teams need to find a way to produce more art in less time, while also meeting the quality and technical specs that have been defined for their productions. This remains a difficult issue to solve for many developers across the industry.

#### What Experience Has Taught Me About Art Production

At the beginning of this article I mentioned that I have been enjoying a career in game art development for quite a long time now. For almost 22 years, in fact. Over the course of my career I have done many things, and almost 100% of those have been art-production related. I was the first employee at the first company to ever use Motion Capture Technology for entertainment and animation purposes - a little company called BioVision, where I started my career in Northern California in 1991. There I learned much about digital animation, working in a software and computer-centric production environment, and dealing with the many joys and challenges presented by working on multiple projects for multiple clients simultaneously.

After five years of pioneering the Motion Capture Service Industry with BioVision I was hired on by one of the company's many clients - Sony Computer Entertainment America. Sony was a big client of BioVision's, and as it turned out they were big enough to not even flinch at the idea of purchasing their own motion capture equipment and building a studio to house it... which is exactly what they did. Then Sony "wooed" me away with the promise of running my own

"I often wondered what it might have been like if I could have taken that wonderful art department 'public' and made a stand-alone business of it. Now I am finally realizing that dream."

department within SCEA, and also by the fact that they were located in San Diego, CA. San Diego is a very nice place to live and to raise a family!

I started at Sony in the Summer of 1996 by hiring the first two employees in what would eventually become a department of 100+... We grew from our start as the SCEA Mocap Department into what eventually became a very large, diverse and highly capable internal game art production department. I still sometimes refer to it as "Sony Insourcing".

The time that I spent building and running the SCEA Product Development Services Group (as it was initially called) gave me a very thorough experience with cutting edge art production techniques and also with operating an 'art outsourcing' group almost as if it were a stand-alone business. Eventually we renamed the department to the SCEA Art & Animation Services Group, which was actually a fairly literal moniker. The department there provided motion capture, animation, 3D modeling and texturing, 3D scanning services (head scan and object scanning), fine art and technical art training, full CG Cinematic production, and a full suite of Video Post Production services. Our client base was comprised of all of Sony's First Party development teams across America and the world. We had a lot of different art production services going on under one very large roof! Still our client (and project) base was limited to only Sony First-Party game titles.

Eventually like many good things my time at SCEA came to an end. After 11 years of growth my position there had gotten to the point where I was mainly handling budgeting, planning, discipline and 'corporate compliance' issues for what had become a very large department. This was not for me, as I longed to return to more of the 'hands-on' art production that I had so enjoyed in the previous years of my career.

In 2007 I took an exciting new position with Midway Games as the Studio Art Director for Midway's main studio based in Chicago, IL. In this role I would have direct access to multiple projects on multiple platforms, from the Game Party franchise on the Wii to the latest editions of Mortal Kombat on the PS3 and Xbox 360 (and more). In addition to working directly with these exciting titles I was also able to get involved with art production issues, directives and policies on a company-wide level. It was an exciting time at Midway as a lot of great and productive things were happening 'on the ground' within the company - particularly with regard to art development. Unfortunately as we now know, Midway was soon to be doomed by the economic crisis that swept across the business landscape in the USA in 2008. Midway closed its doors for good in early 2009 but in my nearly two years as studio art director there I gained a great deal of valuable experience with art outsourcing from the customer-side of the equation. This experience would prove to be vital to the evolution of my career, and to where it stands today.

### The Ultimate Destination

Today I am the proud owner, co-founder and president of Centurion Art Development. Centurion is the culmination of all of my years of experience in art development and production as well as the realization of my goals and aspirations, honed over two decades served 'in the trenches' of the game development industry. Back in the days at SCEA I often wondered what it might have been like if I could have taken that wonderful art department 'public' and made a stand-alone business of it. Now I am finally realizing that dream.

Centurion Art Development is built from the ground up to be a highly capable, extremely reliable, scalable and affordable production partner for our clients. We recognize and understand exactly what our clients face in their own productions, and we have built our company to serve as the perfect resource to meet their needs. Our focus is on providing the highest quality 3D modeling and animation services, 2D concept, design and illustration, and HUD and UI development work.

Over the course of my long career I have learned several important lessons well.

### Among them:

- Bad outsourcing experiences can cost more in internal time for the client's employees than producing much of the art internally would have!
- Going with the lowest cost vendor does not save any money in the end - it actually costs more.
- Tight production management is vital! A great outsourcer will provide this for you... as well as consistent, clear and timely communication throughout the course of a project. In fact outsourcing even major components of your project's art development should actually be a nearly hassle-free and worry-free experience, if you can imagine it. With the right kind of partner it can be.

At Centurion we focus on providing a GREAT customer experience for our clients. Our primary goal is to build long-term, reciprocating relationships so that we can continue to serve our client's requirements project after project. We understand that there is only one way to achieve this goal -



At Centurion we offer high quality, reliable, flexible and affordable art development and production services to our clients across the globe. We are based in China where we have built a state-of-the-art studio facility and we have staffed that facility with seasoned, experienced and highly talented artists from all across the country. My business partner and co-founder of Centurion is Leon Wang. Leon has nearly 15 years of experience in managing art production in China, and has been a leader of large teams and various game art production groups for his entire career. Through our similar career experience, Leon and I recognized in each other the kind of determination, experience, and core values that have allowed us to build what we believe to be the ultimate in outsource art production studios today.

through quality, consistency, reliability and fair pricing. For me it has been a long journey from the beginnings of my career in motion capture back in 1991 to today, where I am back to doing exactly what I love to do. I am as excited about the future of game development - and particularly about the future of art in game development - as I have ever been at any point in my career. With each new project that we take on the excitement continues to grow! Every time I see beautiful new assets posted up to our client forums, I get a new chill. In many ways I feel as though this exciting adventure is just beginning - all these years down the line... and I am very happy to be here!

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# A formidable talent on the rise

**T**hroughout the history of poker, women have been challenging stereotypes of it being only a 'man's game' and breaking new ground. From Poker Alice, to Barbara Enright's induction into the Poker Hall of Fame and beyond; women have helped pave the way for other women to make their mark in the poker industry.

► Out of the growing number of females who are making a name for themselves on the felt, Maria Ho particularly stands out. Maria is an icon for inspiring other women through both her incredible accomplishments and positive attitude as she quickly makes her way to the top of her field.

Maria moved with her family from Taiwan to Los Angeles when she was four years old. By watching her parents build a successful real estate business from the ground up she learned at an early age that working hard and taking chances can be rewarding.

When she was in college, Maria started playing poker and she successfully won money from her friends, her family, and anyone who was willing to play against her. Some of the guys, who held poker nights told her she had no chance at winning but let her join in and she happily walked out with her winnings. No one, including Maria, knew that those friendly games at college and low stakes cash games at nearby Indian casinos would lead to a professional and lucrative career.

Drawn in by the competitive and psychological aspects of the game, Maria continued to grow as a player. And increased in levels as she improved her game. She put aside her winnings towards building a poker bankroll. After playing for a year or so she tried her hand at tournament poker. She made the final table at a small \$300 buy-in at Hollywood Park and any thoughts she had of turning back were laid to rest.

"I got hooked on poker when I made that final table. I thought I was a great poker player," she laughs, "I figured out pretty quickly afterward that I just got lucky."

In 2005, Maria graduated from the University of California, San Diego with a major in communications and a minor in law. She had originally planned to attend law school, but she had been drawn in by poker. She was now playing high stakes poker, and had grown her bankroll to a point where she was comfortable in making a move to become a full time professional poker player.



"I think my strength in poker is my ability to read the other players. I'm observant and can get a read on a player as a whole. I have good instinct on the table dynamics."

"I was just out of college and I decided that if I was going to try to play professionally that was the time to do it," says Maria about her decision.

Since Maria's start as a professional player, she has gone on to become one of the top female pros with over a million dollars in winnings. In the World Series of Poker 2007 Main event she was the last woman standing, finishing in 38th place and took home a prize of over \$200,000. She went on to cash twice in the 2009 WSOP and cashed three times in 2010.

"I think my strength in poker is my ability to read the other players. I'm observant and can get a read on a player as a whole. I have good instinct on the table dynamics," she says. "My biggest weakness is not always following through on those instincts."

In 2010, Maria added a final table and 10th place finish at the World Poker Tour's Bellagio Cup and a final table and 6th place finish at the World Series of Poker Circuit Event: South Africa.

This year, Maria looks to bring even more success. She started off 2011 with a bang, taking home \$73,614 for a second place finish in the Aussie Millions 8 game. The 2011 WSOP also brought more accomplishments for Maria when she broke the record for winning the largest cash prize ever for a female player in the North American WSOP, when she came in 2nd in the 5K No Limit Hold'em Event.

"I am so fortunate to be able to play poker. I hope that other women are motivated by what I accomplish. I hope they see what I have done and go out and play. Women can do anything, we just can't be too intimidated to try."

"It is all a blur to me now. I realized the magnitude of being so close when they put the bracelet between us. The bracelet was all that was in my mind. It wasn't the money. It was the bracelet," she said about her experience. "It is bittersweet, being so close. I know I did well, and I am proud of what I accomplished, but as a poker player I always want more."

"Being a woman might have added some pressure, but to be honest I wasn't thinking about it. It is more about being the best poker player that I can be, not necessarily the best female player."

Maria's vast talents also lie beyond the poker tables. She has shared her knowledge of poker as an on-camera host for the WSOP, a commentator for the live WSOP final table broadcasts on ESPN 360, and a writer for several poker publications.

In 2009, Maria was seen on the CBS Emmy Award winning television show The Amazing Race with fellow poker pro and 2008 Last Woman Standing, Tiffany Michelle. "Strong women are always labeled but strong men are looked up to. I wanted



to show that women can do anything. It (Amazing Race) was the hardest thing to do. I was challenged to push myself to the limit and was in situations that I would never think I could do," she says.

Maria is also a very talented singer and was in the third season of American Idol where she was chosen for "Hollywood Week." She also appeared as a panelist on Anderson Cooper 360 in a segment called 'Breaking Into the Boys Club' where she was joined by TV host and best-selling author Suze Orman, former Clinton White House Press Secretary Dee Dee Myers, and neurosurgeon Katrina Firlirk discussing what it takes for a strong woman to fit into traditionally male occupations in today's society.

Currently, Maria lends her time to two current projects, Rise Poker and The River Poker Series which guarantees a three million dollar prize pool at the Winstar Casino in Thackerville, Oklahoma.

"I don't even think many people realize that there are big tournaments in the mid-west with big prize pools," said Maria. "I love playing poker all over but there is a different atmosphere at the Winstar and in the mid-west in general. It is very competitive but laid back and friendly. It reminds me of why I started playing poker and why I love the game."

Maria joins the 'Prince of Poker', Scotty Nguyen, Survivor-China contestant and professional player Jean-Robert Bellande and G4's 2 Months, \$2 Million's Dani 'Ansky' Stern as the faces of Rise Poker. Rise Poker is a pay by month poker site that aims to keep online poker available to American players.

What is next for Maria Ho? Legends of Poker at the Bike, the Winstar, and WSOP Europe are all in the plans.

One day she hopes to take over the family business. "Taking over my parents business is still what I plan to do in the future. I don't know that I will play poker when that happens. I like to give everything 100 percent and I don't think that I would be able to do both to that level," she says. "I will still play poker just not as a serious career like it is now."

"I am so fortunate to be able to play poker. I hope that other women are motivated by what I accomplish. I hope they see what I have done and go out and play. Women can do anything, we just can't be too intimidated to try."

[WomanPokerPlayer.com](http://WomanPokerPlayer.com)



# Xenonauts

Prepare for an alien invasion!

1 October, 1979: Unidentified forces presumed of extra-terrestrial origin arrive in Earth orbit. Panic spreads globally when attempts at communication fail and initial attempts to repel the invaders as they scout the upper atmosphere are met with heavy losses and little success. The only successful interception occurs over the Baltic sea, conducted by modified interceptors that appear at least partially resistant to the extra-terrestrial weaponry. A clandestine organisation known only as the 'Xenonauts' establishes communication with the major world powers and claims responsibility, demanding both funding and authority to operate within their territory and airspace in exchange for protection.

- For humanity, a glimmer of hope remains – if they can withstand the attacks long enough unravel the secrets of the alien aggressors, the Xenonauts may find yet a way to defeat the alien invasion. Should they fail, millions of years of human history will be brought to a close in mere months...

If the basis of 'planetary defence simulator' Xenonauts sounds a little familiar to some of the more experienced gamers out there, you won't be too surprised to discover that Goldhawk Interactive's debut title leans rather heavily on the mid-90s classic X-Com/UFO: Enemy Unknown.

And for fans of the game there could be an interesting battle on the horizon. Goldhawk Interactive's indie 'reimagining' is set to go head-to-head with an official remake of X-Com produced by gaming big-hitters, Fireaxis.

Interesting times ahead, especially for Goldhawk Interactive's fearless leader, Chris England. We caught up with Chris as he prepared for the launch of a game which has already seen huge success in alpha testing. Not only is England tackling the might of Fireaxis but also facing up to the difficulties of being an indie game development rookie.

"We're keeping it an incredibly deep and very punishing strategy game, while trying to polish it up so it is far more accessible for beginners than the original."

"The 'company' actually only consists of me, and a whole bunch of people working on freelance contracts (some longer than others). My office is my bedroom. Such is the glamorous life of an indie developer!" Chris joked as we conjure images of an especially short commute to work.

"The company came about because I didn't particularly enjoy my job at the time (I used to work in business consulting) and decided to branch out a bit. I started Xenonauts about two and a half years ago and ended up going full time on it about four months ago now.

"The funding initially came from my life savings, but over the past year the pre-orders have really taken off and now represent enough income for us to develop the game from (I've since made most of my life savings back). The budget of the game continues to expand as the income stream expands, which allows us to do things that we wouldn't have been able to do otherwise. People are generally willing to work with us at reduced rates because we're indies, but you still need a certain amount of money to find really talented artists and programmers. Thankfully we've been operating in that zone for a while now and the quality of the final game will be dramatically higher because of it - good news for everyone!"



"It was one of those strategy games that had a ridiculously large sweep of features even for a modern game - it was basically two full games in one, intricately connected with one another, and with loads of cool touches. I remember the first time the aliens attacked my base and I was actually fighting a battle in an accurate recreation of my base. That was a "Wow!" moment. So was the first time I discovered the nasty surprise the Chryssalids had up their sleeves. Heck, you got one of those moments every time you saw a new alien or researched a new piece of battlefield kit. It was a wonderful game and I'm astonished the genre is not bigger than it is.

"The reaction from the fans has been fantastic, as we were the heir apparent to X-Com for a very long time. Even now Firaxis have appeared with their own offering, we're still more faithful to the original while they've gone down a more innovative route. The thing is, X-Com hasn't aged very well - the UI is almost unusable now and though it is good fun to play there's plenty of obvious issues with it. We're taking the basic model and transplanting it onto modern technology, but not modernising the key gameplay too much (I think if you did, you'd end up with something like what Firaxis are doing). We're keeping it an incredibly deep and very punishing strategy game, while trying to polish it up so it is far more accessible for beginners than the original."

The more support Goldhawk Interactive receive through pre-orders and Alpha testing, the bigger budget the developers will have to achieve their epic vision of how Xenonauts should be played out. And with impressive figures so far, fans of the game look set to be rewarded with a nicely polished product.

Chris is confident that the early support will be justified and that with some hard graft the fans will be rewarded: "We're up past 4,000 pre-orders now they're coming in at a good pace now. Given our price point, I'd consider that to be quite a success. Obviously we're striving for a lot more than that but the curve seems to be upwards as we're putting more and more content into the game and the buzz generates around the project.



Xenonauts was such a huge hit in the 1990s that a remake was inevitable, but it was actually relatively low budget efforts which inspired Chris to take on the epic project of doing justice to the X-Com title. Whilst Xenonauts remains faithful to the key facets of the original, it's able to give real cutting edge dimensions due to the leap in modern technology afforded to today's developers. Initial reaction from those who have tested the game appears to be favourable.

"I spent far too much of my childhood playing X-Com to ever really think the Eastern European remakes that have appeared over the years really did it justice - they just never quite scratched the itch," England says.



"Trying to make a full-blown strategy game the size of X-Com and making it to commercial quality is a monstrous task, and I'm glad that I lacked the foresight to realise that in advance.

"Getting together a team capable of doing it is incredibly hard if you don't have the cash to pull them together the conventional way. Now we've built up enough momentum with the project things are much easier, but I spent most of the first year of the project assembling a team capable of building a game. The remaining year and a half has been making that happen and improving on the original (and extremely basic) design.

"In terms of publicity, indie games are all the rage now. We've been helped immensely by the growth of news blogs like Rock Paper Shotgun that provide an alternative to print magazines and are willing to cover indie games even at early stages, and of course we've benefitted hugely from the announcement of the X-Com shooter and the backlash against it."

That Firaxis announcement will have provided a certain level of shock and awe to the Goldhawk Interactive ranks, but Chris is largely philosophical that the gaming world has enough space for two X-Com inspired titles.

"I'm surprisingly relaxed about it actually. I have a huge amount of respect for Firaxis and while their initial announcement was a rude shock, it quickly transpired that the game they are making is quite different to the one we are making. Ours is more of an old-school PC strategy game, theirs is more of a streamlined tactical game that is more accessible and designed for consoles as well as PC. I think they fill reasonably different niches so I hope we'll benefit from the increase in interest around the franchise rather than suffer because they've eroded our core market. Our pre-order figures support that theory so far.

"We're hoping to release the game before the Firaxis remake comes out, but obviously it is available for pre-order on our website at any time."

To find out the very latest from Goldhawk Interactive go to [xenonauts.com](http://xenonauts.com)

"The feedback on the game has been excellent so far and we do our best to listen to it. I guess the proviso is that anyone willing to pre-order right now is probably a huge X-Com or strategy game fan so they're capable of imagining what the game will look like on release, and they are very pleased with it based on its potential. If we released our current build as a final game I don't think it'd get a very good reception - we've got a lot of work to do still."

Whilst it is the fans who will receive the ultimate reward upon Xenonauts' official release, Chris too will surely get huge personal satisfaction from seeing through the project from start to finish. It's always a huge leap of faith to take a career change, but Chris will be keeping his fingers crossed that his 'gamble' has paid off in more ways than one.

He said: "There's a core team of about 12 who are long-term freelancers responsible for a major part of the game, mostly working part time. I think we have about three or four people working full time on it now, including me. Then we have literally dozens of freelancers and contractors who are involved on a more short term basis working on smaller elements of the game. Most people are industry professionals, or at least employed in related industries (two of our concept artists are graphic designers, for instance).

"I'm 25 now, and started this project when I was 22 and only 6 months onto the graduate scheme at my previous employer. I'm based in London and I don't actually have any useful skills in terms of building a game - I can't code, model in 3D or do 2D art. My areas of expertise are design, writing, marketing and the business / financial side, but basically I do anything that we don't have a contractor to do.

"As you can imagine, it was a bit of a tough sell to get the project set up, but paying people did help. I paid everyone working on Xenonauts at least a token rate to make it clear that I valued their time (and to make it clear that I was the one leading the project). I think I've gotten pretty good at what I do, but it's certainly been a learning curve!"

**"Making games is difficult. Why do you think so many indie games are 2D platformers?"**

Launching a start-up in any industry is always fraught with difficulties and concerns and it's been no different at Goldhawk Interactive. But Chris believes that being an 'indie' actually helps their cause in many respects.

"Making games is difficult. Why do you think so many indie games are 2D platformers?" He says.



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# Star Arcade

## Putting the social into gaming

Harri Myllylä and Remco Smit, mobile entertainment veterans who were at the forefront of Europe's ringtone and logo boom at the turn of the century are now making big steps in the brave new world of social and casual gaming.

- ▶ The duo worked at Finnish international mobile and web portal Jippii in 1999, a platform which quickly became one of the region's biggest players. Their current venture, Star Arcade, a cross-platform solution for mobile and social gaming, is already attracting a large amount of attention with close to one million registered users in less than a year since launch. The ambition is to take that figure to 50 million in the next two years, a big task but one which Star Arcade's CCO Remco is confident of achieving.

"Looking at the technology that we have, looking at the distribution from which we are already getting so many positive signs, we aim to have 10 million users by the end of the year and we estimate that we will go to 50 million users within the next two years."

Star Arcade takes the success of mobile and social gaming and gives it the added extra of allowing users to play friends and opponents from around the world on a variety of platforms. You can play Star Arcade's portfolio of games on Facebook, iOS, Android, Blackberry, Nokia, Samsung, Windows and most of the other main operating systems – the beauty of the Star Arcade model however is that there is no barrier between playing opponents cross platform. It seems like utopia for casual gamers, but an ideal that is being made very real by the guys at Star Arcade.

"Our basic idea with Star Arcade from the very beginning has been to enable people to play games and communicate with each other, regardless of the device that they own or regardless of the OS that they are on," says CEO Harri Myllylä.

"That has been our guiding principle in terms of features or functionality, so as an end user I can be on my iPhone, Android, Nokia, Blackberry, Samsung, or I could be playing from Facebook and my friend could be on any of those platforms.

"Our basic idea with Star Arcade from the very beginning has been to enable people to play games and communicate with each other, regardless of the device that they own or regardless of the OS that they are on."

"We can be playing against each other, we can chat at the same time and we can see how we develop, so it is really a place for people to meet their friends, meet new people and play games with those people."

"We are very happy with engagement and with the number of people that are coming back and now it is really time for us to step up on marketing and to take the community higher, in terms of numbers."

The principal behind Star Arcade is such a simple one and one which publishers and developers have tried to tackle for many years, without any real success. In an ideal world we should be able to interact with gamers across platforms, just the same way we can interact with people via a mobile phone conversation. However, breaking down those technological barriers has been the holy grail, up until now.



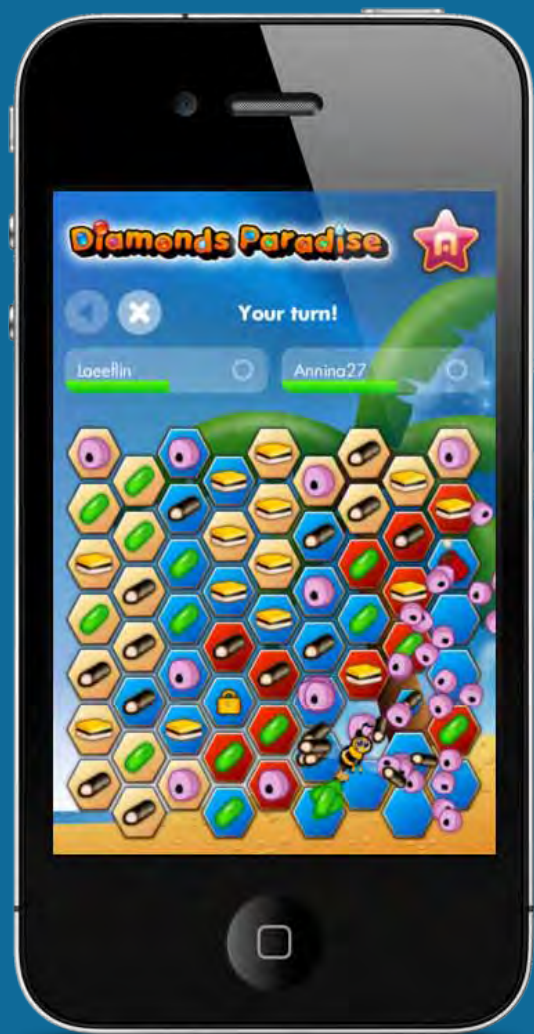
"It is not that easy to build this from a technological standpoint," Remco points out when asked why nobody else has put together a similar solution.

"We expect that cross-platform game play will become a requirement in the future; more and more companies are working towards this. Now there are a few companies that allow you to play Facebook against iOS or Facebook against Android or vice-versa; but the other platforms are actually quite tricky to implement and even the companies which have succeeded are still doing event based gaming, meaning that you still do something within the game and then the other person can react on that. What we now do is show that in real-time, meaning that you can actually see what the other person is doing in real-time on your device screen."

"Why is nobody else doing it? Well we have many years of development in the platform already, the company is very young but the technology has been developed and integrated into Star Arcade, it has been under development for many years. Other companies can and will do this and by my estimation real-time cross-platform gaming will be mainstream at some point in the future – but it is still a lot of work, especially to develop it. It is less work to make it cross-platform on high scores only but it is still very difficult to make it cross-platform when it is real-time player against player – which is what Star Arcade's technology can do."

The guys at Star Arcade recently signed a distribution deal with Saudi Telecom Company, a partnership expected to promote Star Arcade games to its 25 million subscribers in the local market. With focus in other emerging markets such as India, Africa, the Far East and South America, the company is hopeful that they are well placed to take advantage of the impending mobile technological catch-up with the rest of the world.

Harri Myllyla explains the theory: "We looked at some stats which show us and tells us that in those developing markets most of the internet users are accessing internet through their mobile devices and mobile devices only."





"We have looked at the devices in the market and what will be the most fun for people to play against each other. In the near future we plan to open up our platform for third parties and this means that any game provider or game developer could start to use our technology in order to launch their own mobile realtime games across all the various platforms."

"We know that communicating with people is important, being online and being connected with each other, especially in South East Asia and those markets is important."

"We like to position ourselves so that we can play a strong role in certain markets and there is definitely less competition in those markets at this point. Obviously the revenue per user is a little bit lower but very often those countries have a lot of people."

"It's an investment which we have made and we are ready to pay at this point – to be one of the first in those markets."

Star Arcade's current portfolio of games may not include blockbusting graphics or epic content, but that's not to say we won't see any of that in the future. Remco is quick to point out that the technology is already in place to take on some of the bigger, memory-sapping games, it's just a case of waiting for the mobile device technology in their targeted territories to catch-up.

"It's an investment which we have made and we are ready to pay at this point – to be one of the first in those markets."

"Our philosophy is that the games should be easy to understand but difficult to master," Remco says using an oft used phrase from casual gaming. "Because there is a social element you can chat with the person in real-time, there are elements where you can buy presents or virtual coins for yourself or put a wish-list where you would like to have a certain gift from somebody and you can buy gifts for other players. There is a whole social element to these games, we want to make it as accessible as possible to the widest group possible."

"Even though our platform can support very heavy games like graphical MMO games and shooters, the mobile handsets don't support those games yet. The fun part is that while the handsets will progress our platform will be able to open out and launch more sophisticated graphical games."

"We have looked at the devices in the market and what will be the most fun for people to play against each other. In the near future we plan to open up our platform for third parties and this means that any game provider or game developer could start to use our technology in order to launch their own mobile realtime games across all the various platforms."

For now though, Star Arcade's growing community of gamers can enjoy addictive games such as Jelly Wars and Diamonds Paradise, interacting across all the major social gaming platforms.

The recently announced chat and virtual goods capability will take Star Arcade's level of social functionality one step further and with the company's marketing push running alongside they should be well on the way to achieving their ambitious community targets.

For more information on Star Arcade visit their website [www.star-arcade.com](http://www.star-arcade.com)





# Nuclei 3D

**C**reative director, technical artist and project lead at Nuclei, Miguel Oubina is a new breed of game developer with a great knack for figuring things out. Young and ambitious he's had a long client list, including HGTV and 2C Media.

Over the years Miguel's worn just about every hat there is to wear in the game production pipeline. To those who know him personally he is calm and composed with a lot of vision, incredibly patient and bluntly honest, a trait that gets on some peoples nerves when he expresses his opinions. He brings his determination and hardnosed work ethic to his clients and games, always striving to deliver the best he and his company can provide.

As an avid gamer and tinkerer he spends what little free time he has teaching Unreal at several universities in south Florida and loves building models and circuits. An indie game developer to the core, he has spent his time making the best out of this interesting and evolving industry.

"From our humble beginnings in 2008, Nuclei has made major strides in just three years," Oubina told WGE:MAG.

"We've become an indie game developer with two shipped mobile titles and three in the works. Being a start-up in Miami isn't exactly easy, this place is hard to get by in, as the gaming industry is virtually non-existent.



"Even though the area is lacking the gaming punch we have made a niche for ourselves."

That niche includes working on some high profile projects, very often putting more into a project than they got out of it. But it's that single-minded work ethic which has driven Nuclei Inc to the company we see today.

Oubina said: "We began editing and animating commercials for HGTV, working long gruelling hours for small videos that didn't really fulfill our creative vision.

"Seeking to free our creativity we moved onto independent projects that have now become our core IP and have set out to create fun games packed with some serious crude humour.

"A decision that has brought us lots of laughs."

"Being one of the few Unreal gurus in Miami, we have been sought out by schools and training organizations, so much so that we now host a yearly indie game summit in September. We have hosted two so far and the third one is looking really promising."

From small acorns mighty oaks grow and the emergence of GT Interactive's Unreal Tournament and its unique modification abilities have allowed Nuclei to move towards educating the next prospects in the Florida gaming stratosphere. "We were all at one point game modders," Oubina explains.

"Tinkering away in a map editor or writing up great stories. Once Unreal Tournament entered the stage, it was such an inspiring game from which the tools gave use a lot of creative license - creative license that planted the seeds for our game related course.

"As time has flown by, we ultimately decided to use Unreal technology on a variety of platforms which has served us very well.

"Being one of the few Unreal gurus in Miami, we have been sought out by schools and training organizations, so much so that we now host a yearly indie game summit in September. We have hosted two so far and the third one is looking really promising.

"We hope to bring our expertise to students, educators and clients all over the world, and build a hub for all things game here in south Florida.

"I first got my interest in video games when I was in high school. While most of my friends were playing games on their graphics calculators I wanted to try making my own.



"We are also keen to open studios abroad in time as well as helping to bolster the growing indigenous Irish industry and to really help put Ireland on the map as a great place for games development."



"After reading the manual for it, I came up with a slot machine game, then a black jack, by the end of the year I had a small collection that I put together calling it Casino. After high school I attended Broward Community College for about a year. Disappointed and frustrated with the lack of computer courses offered, I dropped out. About five years later I found myself tired of blue collar jobs.



"Today we have one released title, and several prototypes in the works, some which include, top down shooters, Role playing games, Kids games, simulators, and many more. Fridge Raider, our first release, was a learning experience."

"It was then when I enrolled at the Art Institute of Fort Lauderdale. I learned the importance of taking things upon yourself and have kept the same attitude through the rest of my life.

"This is the reason why I had completed two internships even before it was a requirement for graduation.

"It is through this constant desire to take my knowledge and skills forward that I met Miguel Oubina. After Infinite bits we started working together on putting together a group of guys that also wanted to work on games thinking outside the box.

"Today we have one released title, and several prototypes in the works, some which include, top down shooters, Role playing games, Kids games, simulators, and many more. Fridge Raider, our first release, was a learning experience.

"It allowed us to learn the pipeline for Apples submission process and getting around all obstacles that got in the way.

<http://wge.assets.moshenltd.com/nuclei3d-tutorial.pdf>



## BRANDON YONG

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## GABRIEL GARCIA

Name: Gabriel Garcia  
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Education: BSc. Game Art & Design at the Art Institute of Fort Lauderdale



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Title: Graphic Artist  
Education: Graduate of American Intercontinental University with a BFA

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# A+E Networks TV to Games

**A+E** Networks, home to *History* and *Bio*, two of the most recognised channels around the world and provider of iconic TV shows such as *Ice Road Truckers*, *Mega Disasters*, *American Pickers* and *Pawn Stars*.

► But the life of a TV show no longer ends on your TV set. More and more we are seeing titles gain an extra dimension in the world of gaming and social media. A+E Networks Digital Media, a division of A+E Networks, is a leading provider of digital content for properties including *HISTORY®*, *Lifetime®*, *A+E Network®*, *BIO™*, *Lifetime Moms* and *Roiworld*. More than 20 million unique visitors per month engage with the company's digital brands across six properties, and millions more consume the content via syndication, social media and mobile.

WGE:MAG spoke with Kris Soumas, Senior Vice President of Games at A+E Networks to discover which TV shows have had the 'Digital Media' treatment and what fans of the History Channel can expect to see in the near future.

"Where many social games start off strong and then fade after a few months, our audience grew fairly quickly and our daily active users have stayed strong ever since. In fact we just celebrated the one year anniversary of the game and it has been played over 200 million times."

"A+E Networks strongly believes that TV shows and social games go hand in hand, which is why we've invested resources in developing games to correspond with our popular TV shows," Soumas said as she talked about the relationship between traditional media and future technology.

"History in particular is a network that is a prime target for gamification as so many of the programs are games in their own right.



have continued that relationship on their latest title, Top Shot.

"We are working with half a dozen developers to launch about 10 games across multiple platforms in Q1. However, for our latest game, Top Shot on Facebook, we are working with the same development team that produces Pawn Stars for us. Their name is Fifth Column Games and they are a relatively new games studio in San Francisco. The team at Fifth Column has a sophisticated understanding of what makes social gamers tick. Social games are a unique type of gaming and the methods for monetization in particular require the developers to have specific DNA -- which Fifth Column Games has proven they have.

Whilst social media platforms such as Facebook are the current vogue playground for casual gamers, there are plenty of other outlets for gamers to get their kicks with smartphone technology offering plenty of options also. So why did A+E go with Facebook versus other options?

"We chose Facebook because it allows for a social style of gaming that allows fans to become involved with the show in new ways and play along with their favorite characters and friends," says Soumas.

"In many ways, Facebook games are like a TV series. We don't exactly create new episodes weekly, but we do roll-out new content that helps extend the experience for the player. The releases often incorporate elements from the show, so in the case of Top Shot we will feature weapons and challenges directly from the show.

"We're excited by the opportunities that mobile gaming offers, so mobile will play a larger role in our History Games Channel initiative in the coming months. We want to keep giving players new ways to remain connected to History games.

"We will be releasing a much more robust games channel on History that allows visitors to the site to earn badges and achievements for playing games on the site. The platform also will allow us to gamify other aspects of the site when we desire. So ultimately users can earn rewards not only by advancing to the next level in a game but also by watching videos or reading articles on the site. The games platform is being rolled out across the entire A+E Networks sites.

Having a game based on a hit TV show helps drive check-ins - the game fuels interest in the show and the show reminds players to go back and play the game.

"The weekly episodes provide a great opportunity to encourage consistent participation and fuel the viral nature of the game, while the game itself gives us a chance to promote upcoming episodes and otherwise engage our most avid fans. It all works very organically. We launched our first social game, Pawn Stars, in 2011."

Whilst many TV networks have jumped onto the social media bandwagon, blindly anticipating millions more fans to tune into their TV show, A+E Networks have taken a more considered approach and have received fantastic encouragement from their first steps in the social media gaming waters.

Soumas is confident they have taken the right approach: "Our first social game, Pawn Stars, which we launched in 2011, has attracted a really dedicated audience that is still strong today. Before we select a show we look at the ratings, the audience engagement, the show premise and decide whether it is a fit - Pawn Stars was a natural fit for us to start and lends itself well to game development.

**"We chose Facebook because it allows for a social style of gaming that allows fans to become involved with the show in new ways and play along with their favorite characters and friends"**

"Where many social games start off strong and then fade after a few months, our audience grew fairly quickly and our daily active users have stayed strong ever since. In fact we just celebrated the one year anniversary of the game and it has been played over 200 million times. The core audience playing that game is males between the ages of 18-34 who check in nearly three times a day and play for about 15 minutes per visit. It's a very engaged audience. We've also continued to invest in the game by adding new challenges, thus keeping it interesting for our most dedicated players. We also pay close attention to game data after launch - what do the players like, what are they rejecting, what do they want more of, etc. Often this will influence or inspire new directions and new updates for Pawn Stars and all other gaming properties."

The key to 'gamification' gold depends heavily on working with the right partners. A+E Networks formed a successful partnership with Fifth Column Studios on Pawn Stars and they



"We're excited by the opportunities that mobile gaming offers, so mobile will play a larger role in our History Games Channel initiative in the coming months. We want to keep giving players new ways to remain connected to History games."

"We believe by unifying a feature set across all of our Games sites we will be well-positioned to offer advertisers unique ways to engage with our active and growing game community."

With so many of the History Channel's TV Shows lending themselves so well to potential video game crossovers there is an absolute wealth of content for potential developers to get stuck into. The imagination runs wild with the possibilities for shows such as Ice Road Truckers and Mega Disasters. For now though A+E Networks are concentrating on their next release, Top Shot, which has been developed with Fifth Column and seems an obvious choice for gamification.

It's early days but Kris has seen the signs for another hit for the History Channel: "We launched Top Shot through a web version of the game at History.com <<http://History.com>> and a sneak peek of the Facebook game can be seen at playtopshot.com. In about month's time we will release the Facebook game in its entirety followed shortly by a mobile game. We'll have cross-promotion activities to link each of the games and the show.

"Looking at the success of shooters on other platforms, we realized that we had the ability to fill the current vacuum for shooters on Facebook. Top Shot is the perfect property to translate into a social first person shooter game because the show already is a game in its own right - with self-taught marksmen testing their skills with weapons from all eras of human history in different historical themed challenges. The show is like a shooter brought to life - now we're bringing that experience back to gaming but in a social setting."



**WGE:MAG spoke to Andrew Marsh, President of Fifth Column Games to get the lowdown on their work on Pawn Stars: The Game and Top Shot.**

**Who Are Fifth Column Games?**

Fifth Column Games ([www.c5games.com](http://www.c5games.com)) is an independent video game studio I helped found in 2011 with industry veterans Adam Lipski, and Mike Fahmie. Located in San Francisco, Fifth Column is dedicated to crafting high-quality games that leverage powerful technologies to deliver fun and unique gaming experiences. As President I contribute heavily to design, but also to engineering, creative direction, and other aspects of running the studio. Adam, CTO, is in charge of the technical direction of game development. He oversees the integration of new or emergent technology into the games, guides engineering, and makes sure that nothing explodes. Mike, founder and Chief Creative Officer, has experience writing particle engines, shaders, renderers, and even working for NVIDIA. Mike oversees the creative direction of on all projects, contributes ideas and vision, and makes sure they can be implemented.

Adam and I are pioneers of social gaming and between the two of us have shipped more than eight titles for Facebook including Pawn Stars: The Game, Mighty Pirates, Happy Pets, Restaurant Life, Spin-It-Up Slots, Know-It-All Trivia and World War II. All three of us love games: love to play them, and even more than that, love to make them.

**How did the meeting of AE and Fifth Column come about?**

I first connected with Kris Soumas, the head of games at A+E Networks through a mutual friend. She gave me advice on business direction and I talked to her about social game development. Pretty soon I was working as a consultant on Pawn Stars: The Game, and soon after I put together a team to take over development.



Was it a particularly daunting prospect to try and create games out of such well known TV shows as Pawn Stars with such popular characters?

Pawn Stars is one of the most popular shows on cable right now, so the project was a bit daunting in that we wanted the game experience to live up to the fans' expectations. Luckily, many of the shows on History have elements that lend themselves well to creating great games. We worked very closely with Kris Soumas and her team at A+E to get feedback that helped us stay true to the spirit of the show while we made sure to create a great game experience. It's been a really successful game so far and we are constantly evolving Pawn Stars: The Game to keep our fans happy. As a result, Pawn Stars has been played over 200 million times.

Was it necessary to bring in a Caricaturist or did you already have someone on staff that could do this?

We do everything in house. We pride ourselves on having a versatile art team and never outsource, something we think is especially important when you're creating art for such a well-known brand.

How enjoyable an experience has it been working on Pawn Stars: The Game and Top Shot?

A+E has been great to work with because they care about the quality of the product and the brand and let this drive the creation of the game. This is the first time I've had a publisher tell me to cut something that would make money because it would lower the quality of the game.

I'm not sure this holds for all of TV but I really enjoy making products for the History audience. They're devoted fans and they care about quality. Give them a good game and they'll play it. Give them a bad game and they won't.

We get to concentrate on making great games. Nobody here wants to spend our days making "lost cow" features, and neither our fans nor our publisher would really go for that. Instead we get to spend time making a sophisticated bartering system and integrating historical facts into game play. It's a great arrangement.



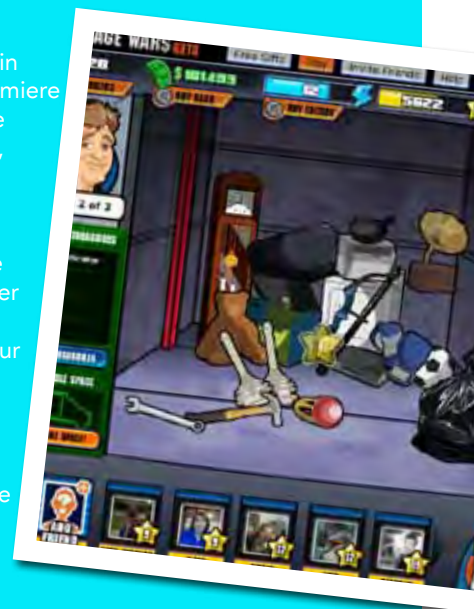
## Is Storage Wars The Next Big Hit?

**Based on the hit A+E series, Storage Wars lets fans test their bidding savvy as they try to become king of the heap.**

We're excited to launch the Storage Wars game in conjunction with the premiere of this season of Storage Wars," said Kris Soumas, Senior Vice President, Games, A+E Networks.

"Storage Wars fans have shown that they are eager to get in on the bidding action themselves and our new game for Facebook lets them do just that. We've put the same emphasis on developing a fun and addictive game experience that A+E brings to its program development."

Storage Wars is a high stakes game that lets Facebook players share in the excitement of storage unit auctions. Players join characters from the show as they are guided through treasure-filled storage lockers on a quest to acquire wealth. Upon logging into the game, players choose a character name and appearance and then enter the map which directs them to auctions around the world where they can take on eager bidders on their own turf. Players then bid with game cash in order to win auctions and earn game cash. As on the Storage Wars television show, players risk losing money for the chance to win Wanted Treasures and a huge profit.





# The Flying Dutchman

**S** Self-styled as 'The most well connected person in the games industry', Dutchman Reinout te Brake is often sought for his connections and advice. As the former strategist of Spil Games, Reinout oversaw the foundation from a young games company to one of the most recognized casual games enterprises in the entire industry – it took him less than three years.

► Reinout left Spil Games in his native Netherlands in 2008, to start up his own company. Six months later MMO Life was born, the first localized MMO games network.

Reinout's story is perhaps not as unique as it is poignant. With his own start-up capital, late night meetings around the kitchen table, and weekend programming, the first portal in Wordpress went live in January 2009. Within 12 months an additional 10 MMO portals were also live, covering the regions of Europe, North America, Brazil, India and China.

But transformation didn't take place there. Instead it paved the way for a new strategy, with the establishment of an eco-system of MMO games, bringing traffic and game sign-ups to MMO developers through affiliate partners. From this transformation iQU.com was born!

To many Reinout is considered influential in the games industry. With a passion for entrepreneurship, strategies and change he is frequently featured in the media.

His work methods fall nothing short of controversial. Often taking a radical approach from vision and idea creation, to architecting strategies and execution. With his 'Imitate and Innovate' slogan, he has transformed companies, bringing in new concepts, methods and ideas based on proven business strategies and success formulas.

His stern, sure-fire and entirely present persona, cuts him an interesting character in the world of games. One thing is for sure; instantly recognisable within the industry for his sock-less feet, slight Eastern Holland accent, Partagas-Havana No.2 cigar in the corner of his mouth and an iPhone stuck to his ear.

**"As long as we have a relationship with an individual or a business entity, we'll do our best to provide the best service we can to help them meet their goals – whether that means finding a new game to love, or making sure we're helping them optimize their marketing campaigns."**



If the PR's biography on Reinout te Brake may seem a little far-fetched for some within the games industry, the charismatic Dutchman certainly has that undoubted touch of arrogance which would back up any argument regarding his achievements.

"When I first spoke of my plans within the games industry, my family's reaction was along the lines of 'How sweet. You must enjoy playing games.' Once I secured the first round of funding, which was in the millions, their views changed and they could see how serious I was," te Brake tells WGE:MAG as we look back on his dynamic entrance into the industry.

"I was focused on figuring out how to make it easier for gamers to find games. After five or six years dedicated to the games industry, it dawned on me that loads of marketing budget was spent on getting gamers to buy the same game over and over. Why not help gamers find as many games as possible that are tailored to their preferences and likes? That's when the idea of iQU was born."

"Today, we ensure that our gamers find the right games throughout their game career. From ages 0-88 we offer them games that, based on their history, game-play and preferences, are exactly what they want. Not only are we helping the gamers, we serve game developers by helping them find active players, not just registrations. Active players have the highest chance to become paying players. Our goal is to grow with developers to make ROI on their marketing budget."

iQU was founded in 2009, with the aim of servicing the online interactive entertainment market. The fast-paced growth of the gaming industry often left little time to garner information about those very gamers driving that growth. With that dilemma in mind GameriQU was created by te Reinout's team – a sophisticated platform which maps gamer behaviour providing the Dutch company with a comprehensive database of online gamer profiles.

"GameriQU tracks gamer activities wherever they happen, across multiple platforms and around the world," says te Reinout.

"We apply this behavioural knowledge to form connections between gamers, publishers and advertisers, creating a more robust marketplace for online games - a smart approach to the online games business."

"As gamers, one of the reasons we founded iQU was to develop a more efficient system for gamers to discover games, and for advertisers and publishers to distribute them. With great new games becoming available every day, we simply didn't want to miss a thing. And that means we're playing on multiple sides of the online games business spectrum."

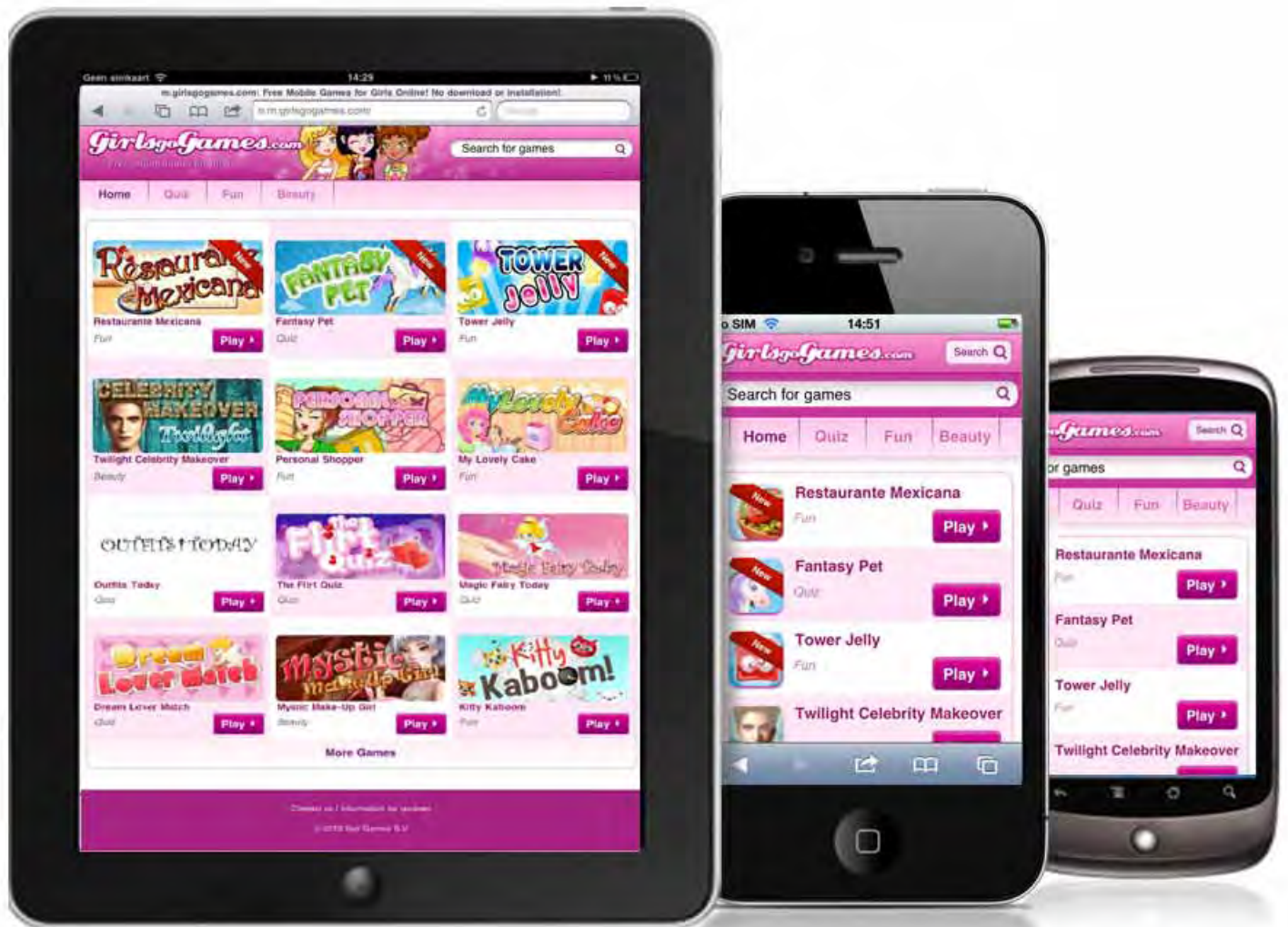
The murky world of analytics is one often derided by those on the outside of the equation. However, the Reinout te Brake model is one which its founder will bring a new level of confidence to the marketplace.

"We're adamant about adhering to the highest possible standards for iQU and all of our products," says te Brake. "We're committed to transparent reporting on our activities on behalf of all of the audiences we serve – for the good of gamers, our clients and our industry."

"As long as we have a relationship with an individual or a business entity, we'll do our best to provide the best service we can to help them meet their goals – whether that means finding a new game to love, or making sure we're helping them optimize their marketing campaigns."

iQU currently boast an impressive portfolio of clients, including Bigpoint, Gameforge, Aeria Games, Riot Games, Ubi Soft amongst others. For more information on GameriQU visit their website [www.iqu.com](http://www.iqu.com).





# HTML5

## The future of multiplatform gaming technology



**M**umbai based game development start-up, Nileegames have been on the scene for a little over 12 months, and their progress over the last year has been fairly rapid.

- WGE:MAG caught up with the start-up's Chief Executive Officer, Anand Jha, to find out what they have been up to and how they are embracing the brave new world of HTML5.

"HTML5 is a revolution on multiplatform gaming technology," Jha told us from Nileegames' Mumbai base.

"Games can be played on all major modern gaming platforms – iOS, Android, Facebook, PC and Mac and the numbers of potential players for these games are increasing day by day."

Nileegames have been working with Dutch gaming powerhouse Spil Games recently providing them with high quality HTML5 games for their portals.

"Due to extensive demand of HTML5 games, we started developing games on HTML5 platform and providing these games to HTML5 game publishers, we welcome game publishers who need games on this platform," Jha says of the business he started after six years in the industry, it appears that during that time the Indian developer and publisher has become a pure advocate for the gaming framework.

"After working on other mobile native and online platforms, I found that applications on native stick with only one platform and porting games on these platforms costs a lot. So I decided go with HTML5, which provides a multiplatform solution so I brought together an expert team which is dedicated towards HTML5 and doing innovative research on HTML5.

"I understand this technology is still in its early stage, and off-course there are drawbacks, but it provides on unified way to make rich-media games on almost any platform. Games on browser based HTML5 platform give instant access to

**"I understand this technology is still in its early stage, and of-course there are drawbacks, but it provides on unified way to make rich-media games on almost any platform."**



audience on Windows, Mac OS X, Linux, iOS, Android and Windows Phone 7. The major argument against HTML5 is performance vs. native application. whilst this is true to some extent, the gap will continue to close as rendering engines continue to show dramatic improvements with the lead of Google Chrome and other browsers. At this point it won't matter if you are developing a native app or an HTML5 app, because you will be able to use as many resources or all of the resources you need in either case.

Nileegames' work with Spil Games has taken them to some fairly interesting places, quite fast and they have already produced one game which is sure to excite, whatever platform it's played on.

"We have created a game "Family Camping Vacation" for Spil Games; it's a story based hidden object game with few mini-games in it, the story is around a family who plan for camping trip at national park on summer vacation, this game has eleven unique levels with some nice conversation between family members and a roadmap to show their progress. Rewards and high scoring system are also implemented in this game and can be playable for long hours.

"Family Camping Vacation is a HTML5 browser based game made for mobile devices; players can access this game on their iOS and Android devices through [m.girlsgogames.com](http://m.girlsgogames.com). "The scope of this game was big on the HTML5 mobile platform, we faced many difficulties during the production, and asset loading was the biggest problem we faced, at the early stage of the production, game performance was very slow, assets were not getting loaded properly, we had memory issues and we were facing unwanted results on iOS and Android devices. To solve this problem my development team produced a great effort and we got the solution of dividing assets into chunks, it gave us capability to control memory as well. Now our games load perfectly and give you that native application feel."

It's early days for HTML5 but the potential for the framework to work on all platforms is one which is sure to attract developers and publishers, new and old. So did Nileegames' relative inexperience in the market help in that they didn't have too many processes already set in place?

"We're experimenting with our games on mobile sites, finding out what works and what doesn't, and acting fast on what we learn," says Jha.

"HTML5 use has definitely been picking up, with browsers rapidly adopting HTML5 specifications—but we're waiting for consumers to update their browsers. HTML5 isn't ideal for out-of-date browsers, which a sizeable chunk of the population still uses on its computers and mobile devices. So in order to ensure players on any device have access to games wherever they are—regardless even of internet connection—we still make content for native apps as well. "We currently have a hybrid mobile strategy, developing both HTML5 content and native apps. But browser vendors are opening up to HTML5, so while it will take browser-based games time to catch up to the quality level of Flash, the future looks bright."

Whilst it's easy to see why gaming rookies such as Nileegames are embracing HTML5, there is an even bigger question for some of the bigger companies like Spil Games to get involved. But on the surface at least they seem keen to get behind the platform: "Our philosophy has always embraced the spirit of free, accessible fun for our players on any platform, whether from behind a desktop computer at work or on the run with a mobile phone. Which is why we saw something special in browser-based mobile gaming, recognizing revolutionary potential in HTML5—a set of technologies poised to challenge the dominance of native apps in the gaming industry by outfitting browser-based games for any device.

The technology is key in Spil Games' mission to unite the world in play.

Head of Licensing at Spil Jeroen Bouwman commented "We have licensed several Flash games from Nileegames, so we know their expertise and the quality Anand and his team delivers. We look forward to a fruitful and long-term relationship with Nileegames."

With one of Europe's biggest and best on board, Anand Jha can now take Nileegames into the bright future of HTML5 development and he's keen to encourage other developers to give their full support to browser-based gaming.

He said: "We are now dedicated towards HTML5 games and developing games for both casual and social audience. We are thinking of Nileegames future as a developer and publisher of this upcoming booming technology with HTML5 games and constantly looking for new business opportunities in this era.

"Developers who are seeking opportunity in HTML5 games, must try. There are many open source library and engines are available. HTML5 is the future of multiplatform gaming technology, so this is the right time to grab this technology and be a part of the HTML5 gaming industry.

"We welcome all developers if they want to showcase their work to us and we are also constantly looking for news games to license."

**"HTML5 is the future of multiplatform gaming technology, so this is the right time to grab this technology and be a part of the HTML5 gaming industry. "**



# Get in the Game:

## Community Management For Indie Game Devs

Ryan Arndt has worked on social media/community management for the International Game Developers' Association, SuperBetter, Casual Connect, the Canadian Video Game Awards, Merging Media Transmedia Conference, and various Indie game studios. In this feature he focuses on positive community and social media management for the video game and interactive space.

Being a small business owner is not easy. Doing it in a creative field like game development doesn't make it easier. Time is the most precious resource that an indie game developer has, and spending it wisely is key. As you develop your next awesome game, remember to build an audience for the game as you do dev.

### KNOW YOUR MARKET.

You can't get word out about your game without knowing about where your market meets. And there are lots of players, and building a strong community will help attract them to your game.

### CONSIDER THE FOLLOWING:

- Facebook - nearly 1 billion people
- Twitter – researching hashtags
- Google+ - not solid enough for a small business to jump on to at this point, in my humble opinion.
- Forums - search for forums around the games you work on - word games? check other word game sites
- Other national social networks (like Orkut in Brazil or RenRen in China)

### IT'S OK TO BE A NOOB.

Yoda was wrong, there is absolutely a "try" in social media. Social media is very much about trial and error and testing what your community likes and engages with. It will take time. Here is where you begin:

- Invite people in your network
- Share meaningful content, share it out from your new twitter/facebook to your own networks
- Go beyond people you know and build new relationships via commenting and sharing around other people's content (this part is labour intensive)
- Invite people to get involved with some decisions - (post pictures of your office and ask them if it's how they would arrange it, for example)
- Share rich media – photos/video
- Ask questions to the growing community and keep them engaged.

### CREATE YOUR STRATEGY.

Once you know where to connect with your players you need to develop a communications strategy. This need not be elaborate or ornate. An example of a simple, yet effective strategy should include the following elements:

- Facebook - one post a day minimum. Do it at lunch time for your market
- Twitter - share information about the daily life of your company - check for #hashtags around keywords relating to your game and get involved in conversations/follow people using the hashtags. "Twitter is the grout of your day"
- Create/share engaging, rich content (photos, videos)
- Create content around the values your company supports (mission statement).
- Social media is made for mobile – please embrace it.

### LEARN FROM OTHERS WHO HAVE GONE BEFORE YOU.

Just like in game development and other disciplines there are best practices in social media. By learning from what other people do, you can avoid some mistakes. You can also learn some of their signature social media moves like:

- Creating a developer diary - blog/tweet about your experience creating the game
- Sharing the struggles and successes you have
- Using videos/photos to showcase the people in your studio and the great things they are doing.
- Focusing on engaging content built around what your game brand 'feels' like. What do you want your brand experience to be?

### IMPORTANT THINGS TO REMEMBER.

- Social media is multi-directional and conversational
- Creating a news-feed that is all about you, will not bring people in (Ask yourself, what would you interact with?)
- IF a newsfeed style is created, people will block your updates, and they will be lost. Better to NOT post than to do a newsfeed.
- Do not cross-post from one-network to another – Twitter is a different tool than Facebook.
- For every 10 posts on social media - two can be directly about your brand, four around values/ ideas in that area, three that are fun/ innovative, one that is a test case for what your community likes
- Have fun and don't be afraid to share the cool things you are doing, because you are doing cool things!

Social media is a cheap, effective and powerful tool for any game developer to use to grow their brand. Jump in and as is said on Star Trek, "Engage!"

Connect with me on Twitter

# devmaster

*the leading game development community*

Join us at [devmaster.net](http://devmaster.net)



demo / portfolio. Apply the knowledge you learn in school and continue to create art assets. Keeping pushing yourself to increase your skill level. That said, if you have an opportunity to get your portfolio reviewed, do it! Practice makes perfect.

It really helps to have a well-maintained blog with interesting articles showing your experiences with game development and game art. What if you can't post anything from your current game? It's ok to explain that you can't show anything from the

Character art is harder to break into but not impossible. Maybe show a progression of how you got from sketch to character with brief explanation (probably in a blog) about your inspiration and your tools.

Thriving platforms include Steam, XBLA, PSN, mobile, and Freemium. (Yes, there is a definite bias towards social games.) With the shift towards social and casual, you should know Flash, especially with recent announcements by Epic and Unity about their in-engine support for Flash11. This requires strong 2D skills and facility with a Wacom tablet. It (almost) goes without saying that every artist needs to be good at drawing if for no other reason than you can illustrate feedback or suggestions to others--look good doing it. Split your time studying from life and drawing and painting from imagination. You might even try doing master copies of great artworks (that's how students back then learned), studying human and large animal anatomy, and knowing key artistic foundations like perspective, color and composition.

Study the path of those whose work you really admire. You'll be amazed at some of the secrets you can pick up from doing a little research.

#### POINTERS FOR SPECIFIC SPECIALTIES

- **Modelers:** No Moving Videos. Show still images from different points of view. Show wireframes, unwraps, normal maps, spec maps (all as separate files). Hiring managers want to see the modeling decisions you have made. Stick to Modeling; we see way too many demos where the modeler is also showing animation or special effects and this gets confusing. Focus on what you do best and show only the best work within that piece, whether it's Characters, Weapons, Apparel, etc.

- **Concept Art:** It's really hard to break into the games industry as a concept artist. Hiring managers want to see a lot of early and quick exploration of rich strong shape design, good understanding of color and color theory and the ability to render—all of which their current art department already knows how to do. That said, if you can do amazing concept art AND have an equally good specialty, you might be able to show your creative process through a progression.

- **Animators:** Focus on a couple of high quality moments of animation in your demo and really pay attention to weight, push / pull tests, and fluidity. You'll get hired on two seconds of push

# Catch 22 (Game Artists): Prior Experience Required

By Marc Mencher

**You know the routine: there's this job you really want but you don't have the experience. You could pretend you did but then they want to see your portfolio and odds are you probably haven't finished it (or even gotten around to starting it.) Does this mean that you're doomed to sitting in front of your monitor dreaming about a career as a Game Artist?**

No!

Put down the game controller and pick up that stylus! You've got a ready audience for your work—all you need is a website and some determination. (Oh, and maybe a class or two if you're not up on the latest game art programs, but it's easy enough to get going on that.)

Instead of wishing for a job, it's time for you to make it happen. . .

#### THE ART STUFF

If you're serious about working in the video game industry, you need to get serious about your job hunt, and that includes creating your demo / portfolio. Here are a few pointers whether you're doing one for the first time or updating the one you have:

If all you have is art completed for coursework, don't submit your resume (yet). Competition for these jobs is pretty fierce so you have to have an established career or be a complete (if undiscovered) superstar. A degree doesn't prove your ability and does not entitle you to a job, it just equips you with the core skills you need to perform in the job and to build your

game-in-progress but you can clearly demonstrate that you know how to use the tools. (If you're working on an indie game, creating a production blog is a good way to create some buzz.) Just remember that you're trying to build a career here so don't use the blog for political rants or questionable art.

Avoid fan art in your portfolio (unless it was commissioned by the show and / or the author, and you have permission to show it or link to it.) If you want to join LucasArts to work on the next Star Wars game, don't re-create Darth Vader or any of the original characters. The hiring manager is trying to assess not only your skill but also your creativity, so design original assets that could be used in a Star Wars game. (It's also a chance to show your knowledge of the IP as long as you don't get too geeky.)

Be sure the art in your portfolio is 100% yours. A candidate who went for an interview at a big company included some gorgeous screenshots in his portfolio from a well-known game. The interviewers were very familiar with the game, and queried him about that art. It turned out that those were shots of levels he'd played in the game, NOT levels he'd created! Needless to say, he didn't get the job.

#### THE TECHNICAL STUFF

Today's game industry artist needs to be specialized and technical. Showcase your strengths. Is it 3D? Create some strong environment pieces: one natural, one man-made, maybe something futuristic or fantasy but always totally original.

/ pull rather than an entire unfocused demo. Study the basic motion loops needed for the genre of games your target company publishes and prove that you can do that.

- **VFX:** Show quality in-game effects that make sense and fit the genre. Understanding the Unreal and Unity Engines and their related particle effects systems is a big help. Innovate, don't imitate.

- **Technical Artist:** Understand Unreal and Unity, specifically their scripting languages (MEL and MaxScript). Learn Python. Show examples of your scripts (code), along with little movies of the scripts in action.

#### ABOUT UNREAL:

- If you're an awesome modeler who can do awesome textures, everything needs to end up in Unreal—and it needs to work.
- If you're an animator, make sure you have some Animation Tree going shoe me what your animation. Show me what the animation are doing to textures and your assets in Unreal. Take everything you know about art and apply it in the engine.
- If you do Visual Effects, designing particle effects and coding Cascade (using Unreal's Particle engine).
- About Engines in general: Plain and simple: demonstrate a mastery of your craft and knowledge of the engine your target game company is using.

#### THE NETWORKING STUFF

Regardless of your area of expertise and / or interest, you need to network. Join one of the Social Game Developers groups on LinkedIn, Facebook, etc. It's ok to read and "listen" for a while. Find the sweet spot between total noob and flashy know-it-all.

#### Online Art Community and User Groups

- MeetUp
- LinkedIn
- Facebook
- PhotoShop
- Digital Art Groups

#### Online Resources for Artists

There are a lot of sites out there that provide all kinds of helpful information. Here are a few of the bigger ones:

- [www.CGSociety.org](http://www.CGSociety.org) ([www.CGTalk.com](http://www.CGTalk.com) is the site's forum)
- [www.3DTotal.com](http://www.3DTotal.com) (3DTotal was

founded in 1999 as a simple 3D resource website. Over the last decade the site has evolved into one of the premier CG art websites.)

- [www.PolyCount.com](http://www.PolyCount.com) (Polycount offers 3D videogame artists news, resources and a forum)
- [www.DominanceWar.com](http://www.DominanceWar.com) (The website of a massive annual game art competition)
- [www.ConceptArt.org](http://www.ConceptArt.org) (Offers a forum, news, information about a variety of classes, and contests)
- [www.visualliteracyprogram.com](http://www.visualliteracyprogram.com) (The Visual Literacy Online Program is for both the serious student of any age and the professional artist.)
- [www.theartdepartment.org](http://www.theartdepartment.org) (The first-ever career-driven, virtual and real world art and entertainment development college for both digital and traditional media)
- <http://www.unrealengine.com> (If you don't know what this is, don't apply for a job until you do!)
- [www.design3.com](http://www.design3.com) (This site has over 1K amazing demo's to teach you 2D and 3D art skills.)

#### WHICH COMPANY?

If you're just starting out, even if you have a degree but you haven't landed your first job, keep applying to the smaller studios. It would be exciting to claim Bungie or Blizzard as your first job but you're up against a lot of "veterans" who are already making gorgeous, cutting-edge art.

Apply directly! A seasoned recruiter will rock your world once you have at least two professional games sold on the market. Prior to having professionally published titles the best way to succeed is by directly applying for a job yourself. There is no magic bullet or easy way to skirt around the job hunt.

Stay current on big games or AAA titles, especially the ones that use the Unreal and Unity engines. (This does not mean be obsessed because you need time to work on your portfolio!)

#### CREATING A KILLER DEMO

Find other people who also trying to break into the game industry. (See Networking above.) There are plenty of Programmers; Game Designers, and Web Developers who also need a demo. Combine your skills and create an online demo that rocks. Create mini games that are a logical extension of

your favorite games (or the games of your target hiring company).

Customize your demo for your target audience. If you excel at sci-fi images, approaching EA Sports probably isn't the best career move. Unless the game involves some kind of futuristic sport, they probably don't care that you can do a spectacular rendition of Fenway Park or Tom Brady throwing a perfect spiral pass.

- Keep it simple and easy to navigate
- Customize and target your work for the interviewing studio
- Create original assets
- Never force downloads to view assets
- Create a "brand" for yourself and manage it via social networking sites, etc
- Pay attention to poly count and use it as a measuring stick. Hiring managers want to see how well you used polygons in the art asset itself
- If you are showing your senior project from school, make sure it's finished. Often senior projects are too ambitious and don't get completed so scale it back to reality. Managers hire folks who can complete things
- Show both low poly and high poly work. Tag each image with brief info; the 2D or 3D software you used and how many pixels is usually enough
- Show only your best work. Less is more!

#### MARC MENCHER BIOGRAPHY:

Game Programmer / Technical Producer-turned-Recruiter and Career Coach, Marc Mencher has been in the Game Industry for 27 years. He is the founder and CEO of GameRecruiter [www.GameRecruiter.com](http://www.GameRecruiter.com)

Marc began his career working for Spectrum Holobyte, Microprose and The 3DO Company. While he enjoyed coding, through the experience of developing product and leading teams, he realized that his true passion was helping people plan and manage their careers.

Marc is the author of "Get in the Game! " an instructional book on building a career in the video game industry. His articles have been featured in a variety of industry publications. He is a speaker at game industry conferences and volunteers as an advisory board member for several colleges. Marc has been interviewed on television and radio as an expert on working in the videogames industry. His detailed bio can be found at [http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Marc\\_Mencher](http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Marc_Mencher)

Along with his team of Recruiter / Career Agents, Marc has had the pleasure of representing the game industry's hottest talent, and has helped thousands of people manage their career and obtain strategically important game jobs. Integrity and confidentiality are the cornerstones of his success.



# Majesco

## Lords of the dance

Majesco Entertainment, the publisher behind the Zumba Fitness video game phenomenon and other huge hits such as Twister Mania and Cooking Mama, has been providing video games to the mass market for more than 22 years. But it hasn't been plain sailing for the New Jersey video game supremos, as you would expect of any tech company that's been in such a volatile and turbulent industry as video game entertainment, Majesco has steered itself through ever-changing and choppy waters.

- ▶ With the video games industry set for more change in what are transitional and challenging times, we spoke with Majesco's CEO, Jesse Sutton, to find out what his company has learned from those difficult times and how confident he is about the future in the gaming market. "I have been with Majesco from the beginning, I'm a co-founder and the CEO. I've been making games for about 25 years, it doesn't feel like it has been that long but it has been." Jesse tells us from the company's New Jersey base.

"We have created games on every single platform and throughout the 25 years of the company's history our core competency has always been our relationship with the retailers, especially in the United States. GameStop, Best Buy, Walmart, Target, Toys R Us, Amazon, we have been working with these retailers for many years, building relationships and being able to put product on shelves.

"While we produce all of our games in house, we do most of our development externally and so we work through independent third party developers. To do that we have to have excellent relationships throughout the international development community, which we do, we make games pretty much all over the world. When we look to make a game today we pretty much put out our Development RFP and then we look at three or four ideas or proposals from different teams that we are comfortable with.

"In 2006 when I took over as CEO, the vision of the company changed to focus on the casual gamer. The mom, kids and the family as a whole, within that context we started looking for product, primarily on console or handheld.

"The original Xbox died a swift death when Xbox360 came out so if you were focusing on publishing games for the original console, you got hurt pretty bad. It was a rough time for the entire industry and we were a part of that, we went through a transition and that's when we started focusing on casual games."

The idea was to focus on the casual game, the mass market and primarily focus in areas that we felt good about and saw an opportunity to monetize, and in 2006/7 the right place for us was on handheld and console."

Sutton's appointment as CEO and the subsequent focus on casual gaming wasn't the first significant change of direction that Majesco had encountered. The company had started life as a distribution partner for Woolworth, providing the former retail giant with 'as much Nintendo product as they could find'.

After building up a sizable network of relationships with distributors and third party publishers, Majesco saw an opportunity to start building and publishing their own product. They began by striking up a handy relationship with Hasbro, taking their classic titles to the Nintendo Game Boy and moved on from that fairly low technology threshold into the console market in the mid-1990s, porting top PC games to console, including the Tom Clancy Rainbow Six Series.

In 1998 Majesco made the decision to build their own game from scratch, the end product of which was the critically acclaimed BloodRayne - A fantastic debut success for the company, one which sold over a million copies worldwide and gave Majesco a solid base to begin publishing more of their own branded product.

While building and publishing a mix of hardcore and more casual games, Majesco also created innovative video compression technology, allowing them to enable pure video watching on the Game Boy Advance. Selling more than five million GBA Videos featuring Disney and SpongeBob Squarepants, the format was almost the VHS of video game technology. But as Jesse explains, the video game industry was entering a dangerous period of transition, bringing with it turbulent times for all concerned.

"In 2005 we went through a bunch of difficulties, almost the perfect storm," Sutton says as he looks back. "Nintendo shut the faucet off on all video, literally overnight, with news that the DS was coming out later that year and that ended the GBA Video business literally straight away and that was rough.

"The second difficulty was that we were selling the plug and play products which were really hot at one point. We had a plug and play product called 'Frogger' which was really successful, we did over a million units on that but then every toy company flooded the market with Plug and Play product and that market ended in 2005.

"Then of course there was the famous transition from Xbox to Xbox 360 and PlayStation 2 to PlayStation 3 and that was a rough time for us. We had spent a lot of money on Xbox product and we had to practically cancel the games that we came out with but by the time we came out with them we were already too late as the market already migrated to the Xbox 360.

"With PlayStation we had a great transition from the original PlayStation to PlayStation 2. There was an overlap of about four or five years with both consoles in the market place at the same time, so games were selling for both generations of console, the same held true with the transition from PlayStation 2 to PlayStation 3 for that matter.

"The original Xbox died a swift death when Xbox360 came out so if you were focusing on publishing games for the original console, you got hurt pretty bad. It was a rough time for the entire industry and we were a part of that, we went through a transition and that's when we started focusing on casual games."

Transition is on the horizon once again in the world of console with the next generation of platforms looming large from Microsoft, Sony and Nintendo. But Jesse believes that Majesco is far better prepared and believes that this time it is an entirely different landscape: "I think it is important to acknowledge or be aware and mindful of the nuances that are different in these transitions than those we experienced in the past. For example, we went from the Game Boy to Game Boy Advance, from Game Boy Advance to DS, these were the dominant and in some cases sole handheld devices on the market, and keep in mind the DS had only one rival in the Sony PSP. Now you are talking about both the [Nintendo] 3DS and the new [PlayStation] Vita having to compete with the smartphone industry and that has not been a small challenge to deal with.





"On the console side, you have a whole new set of challenges, which is really battling for the 'entertainment time'. We know that people are doing lots of things at once and multi-tasking has become the norm, but that being said, as far as games are concerned, people are playing games everywhere these days. And whether it's your tablet or a smartphone or your PC or your console or your handheld, it's a lot of places to battle for the time of the consumer.

"When you look at the new console transitions, when you look at Microsoft and Xbox or Sony and PlayStation, they have already amassed a build-up of their platform-specific online userbase that they are going to try and leverage into the next generation platforms that they ultimately release; whether that is PSN or Xbox Live and all of the consumers which have dedicated themselves to those online universes. It's hard for somebody to just walk away from the brand you've already invested in when you have been connected to it for so long. Those are some of the ways the console companies are trying to maintain and build-up their userbases, alongside the top level content they are bringing out."

While Majesco has strategically positioned itself in readiness for the new era of platform technology, Sutton believes that it's an already existing piece of hardware that will lead the way. The Majesco supremo is also anticipating a famous return from our friends in Japan, refusing to write off the fortunes of Nintendo.

"Microsoft has added a new distinction, which I think is very material, nobody is writing it off but the marketplace is giving it a lot less value and underestimating what its potential is going to be – the Kinect. I think the

Microsoft's Kinect technology is going to be a huge influence on games and gaming over the next two to three years and Majesco is going to support that significantly and we feel very strongly about it.

"Additionally, I think historically we have a tendency to count Nintendo out when they go through a little bit of a lull and then they have always surprised everybody and blown everybody away with what they have come out with.

**"We are going to be putting four or five million dollars of investment into the social and mobile space in 2012, it's a significant investment for us and we anticipate that being an important part of the company's overall growth over the next two or three years."**

"Nintendo always has its super content to drive their consoles and they are very innovative.

"The Wii U is very mysterious right now, not many people know much about it, or the content that is going to drive it, or even the tablet which is being added to it. However, I am always very confident in Nintendo as a very smart, first party company and I have a lot of confidence that they will be able to figure it out for the next generation."

Majesco's confidence in Nintendo's bounce-back-ability is not without foundation. The Wii revolutionised the industry upon release and with it Wii Fit which was a hugely successful forerunner to a host of fitness based titles, including, of course, Majesco's Zumba Fitness.

But it's the Kinect and not the Wii's technological potential that Sutton is aiming to unleash.

"Nintendo had already paved the way with the Wii, the Wii had already built a fitness medium that was incredibly successful," Sutton says of the game's 3D movement technology.

"The Wii Fit is one of the bestselling titles of all time, on any platform or format. There's no question that the idea that you could have an interactive entertainment experience that incorporates fitness or dance, or both in our case, has already been established on the Wii - that sense of familiarity was what was really brought to the Kinect.

"What hasn't been done on the Kinect is the killer app which goes beyond just adult women who want to dance. That's going to happen, I strongly believe that is going to happen and I am very hopeful that we are a part of that. As consumers get more comfortable with the user interface of the Kinect, which is a work in progress, I strongly believe that that platform is going to get stronger and at some point hit an inflection point where you will see the hockey stick curve, but it's always about the killer app."

While Jesse and Majesco colleagues work on that 'killer app' they haven't been too busy to not notice the explosion of casual gaming on platforms which don't involve a console. But mindful of the difficulties his company faced seven years ago, they already have the wheels in motion. "We are very focused on social and mobile gaming," Sutton adds.

"We acquired a company which has a history of building games as a service, which is really the core of what social and mobile games are about and where they are going. We think free-to-play, with microtransaction monetization, is the future on mobile and we are going to build games in that context.

"2012 will be the year that we will release five or six products on social and mobile and 2013 we hope will be the year that we start seeing significant return on that investment.

"We are going to be putting four or five million dollars of investment into the social and mobile space in 2012, it's a significant investment for us and we anticipate that being an important part of the company's overall growth over the next two or three years."

# Blood Rayne

**Majesco's BloodRayne was critically acclaimed as a video game, but CEO Jesse Sutton explains how selling the movie rights put the franchise in critical condition...**

We learned a few things from BloodRayne. We learned that creating your own branded title from scratch is incredibly hard, hindsight is always 20/20 but looking back that was the kind of product which we probably should have put a lot more marketing effort behind because it really did have a lot of potential.

It got good reviews, the character herself was one that was well received by the gaming community but we just didn't do enough to market it and really grow it into something special. When you consider what happened to Tomb Raider and Lara Croft, if you are familiar with the BloodRayne character you can see connection with the potential for Rayne to be similar to those other well-known vixens. Then we made a big mistake, which actually Lara Croft didn't make, we gave our movie rights away without caring really what the movie was going to be like. We actually never expected there to be a movie and there has been three movies! Three movies which we had no control over getting made and they were all horrifyingly rated, our fans rebelled and that had a hand in the destruction of the franchise. So lesson learned.

We are in the beginning process of potentially bringing Rayne back in small doses, we just built an XBLA and PSN title for BloodRayne that has done ok this past year and has been well received and well-reviewed. We are making Rayne's comeback a step-by-step process, there is definitely a place in our heart for BloodRayne that we can't just walk away from. Hopefully memory of the movies dissipates and a whole new generation comes.



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